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UX Redesign of the Goodreads app from the perspective of a selected user scenario

BACHELOR THESIS

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Statutory Declaration

I declare that I have developed and written the enclosed Bachelor Thesis completely by myself and have not used sources or means without declaration in the text. Any thoughts from others or literal quotations are clearly marked.

In Prague on the 8th of May, 2023 Dariia Holotova

Acknowledgement

I would like to thank my thesis supervisor, Mgr. Filip Dědic, for his useful advices, and time he dedicated to me during the writing of my bachelor's thesis.

Abstract

This bachelor's thesis presents a UX redesign of the Goodreads application (version 2022) for specific user scenarios, each representing different types of users and their specific needs and expectations from the Goodreads app. The first scenario represents a user who is interested in tracking their reading progress, while the second scenario represents a user who is interested in organizing their physical book collection. The third scenario represents a user who is interested in discovering new books and authors through social media. The primary objective was to improve the user experience of the application and make it more user-friendly.

The theoretical part of the thesis discusses the concepts of UX and UI design, their differences, and the design process, various applications that designers use in their work. Furthermore, this work reviews the history of Goodreads, its direct and indirect competition, and the challenges it faces.

The practical part of the study followed a structured approach to design and refine the user experience of the Goodreads app. It started with wireframing, selecting a grid, and preparing the components, colors, and fonts to be used. Screens were then designed for each scenario, and proposed UX changes were made based on user feedback and basic UX principles. The resulting design was compared to the current Goodreads app, and an interactive prototype was created to demonstrate how it would work in practice.

In addition to redesign of the Goodreads application, this bachelor's thesis also includes user experience testing. A total of six users participated in the testing process, providing feedback on the proposed UX changes and suggesting additional improvements.

The output of the work includes three user flows in Figma, along with an interactive prototype. These prototypes serve as a visual representation of the new design, which can be used to gather feedback from potential users. Overall, the thesis aimed to provide an analysis of the Goodreads application and develop a user experience redesign that would improve the overall user experience.

Key words

mobile application, social reading, reading application, usability, prototyping, user interface, user experience, user scenarios.

Abstrakt

Tato bakalářská práce představuje UX (User Experience) redesign aplikace Goodreads (verze 2022) pro specifické uživatelské scénáře, které reprezentují různé typy uživatelů, jejich potřeby a očekávání od aplikace Goodreads. První scénář představuje uživatele, který má zájem sledovat svůj postup v čtení, zatímco druhý scénář reprezentuje uživatele, který má zájem organizovat svou fyzickou knihovnu. Třetí scénář reprezentuje uživatele, který má zájem objevovat nové knihy a autory prostřednictvím sociálních médií. Hlavním cílem bylo zlepšit uživatelskou zkušenost aplikace a zjednodušit její použití.

Teoretická část práce se zabývá koncepty UX a UI designu, jejich rozdíly a pojmem Design Process. Dále práce zkoumá historii aplikaci Goodreads, její přímou i nepřímou konkurenci a výzvy, kterým čelí.

Praktická část studie následovala strukturovaný přístup k návrhu a vylepšení uživatelské zkušenosti aplikace Goodreads. Začala wireframingem, výběrem mřížky a přípravou komponent, barev a fontů. Následně byly navrženy obrazovky pro každý scénář a navrženy UX změny na základě zpětné vazby uživatelů a základních principů UX. Výsledný design byl porovnán s aktuální aplikací Goodreads a byl vytvořen interaktivní prototyp, který ukazuje, jak by aplikace v praxi fungovala.

Kromě návrhu UX redesignu aplikace Goodreads tato bakalářská práce také zahrnuje testování uživatelské zkušenosti. Celkem se do testovacího procesu zapojilo šest uživatelů, kteří poskytli zpětnou vazbu na navrhované změny UX a navrhli další vylepšení.

Výstupem práce jsou tři uživatelské scénáře v programu Figma spolu s interaktivním prototypem. Tyto prototypy slouží jako vizuální reprezentace nového designu, která může být použita k získání zpětné vazby od potenciálních uživatelů. Celkově cílem práce bylo poskytnout analýzu aplikace Goodreads a vyvinout redesign uživatelského zážitku, který by vylepšil celkovou uživatelskou zkušenost.

Klíčová slova

mobilní aplikace, sociální čtení, aplikace pro čtení, použitelnost, prototypování, uživatelské rozhraní, uživatelská zkušenost, uživatelské scénáře.

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Introduction

Goodreads, launched in 2007, has become one of the most popular reading apps on the market (1). It consistently ranks among the highest-rated apps and remains at number 7 in the App Store Top charts in the Books category as of Spring 2023 (2). With 1.9 thousand ratings, it ranks the highest of any book tracker app, has over 90 million members who have added over 2.5 billion books to their shelves. Goodreads has become a platform that fosters interaction and engagement between authors and readers, making it a hub for book lovers worldwide. (3)

Meanwhile, the Goodreads app has a reputation for being an outdated platform that doesn't listen to user feedback and takes a long time to evolve. In 2022, its website underwent a rather successful redesign for the first time in many years. The goal of this bachelor thesis is to improve the user experience of the mobile app, focusing on three specific user scenarios.

The theoretical part of this thesis focuses on user experience and user interface design concepts, highlighting their differences and general design methodologies. It also includes a look into popular design tools, the history of Goodreads, and its competition.

The practical part of the thesis involves collecting and analyzing user feedback and satisfaction with the app. Based on this feedback, a UX redesign workflow is created for specific user scenarios, and a comparison is made between these user flows and the current app. The main output is an interactive prototype of the new design in Figma, which demonstrates how it would work in practice.

1. UX/UI Design - differences, principles and tools

This thesis considers the field of User Experience Design as the main subject of its study, but it is important to consider two closely related aspects of the design process - User Experience (UX) and User Interface (UI). When creating any product, they are almost inseparable and exist hand in hand.

1.1. UX vs. UI Design

In large corporations, these two departments are separated and independent specialists work in each field. However, it is important to have a close collaboration between UX and UI designers to ensure that the product is not only visually appealing but also functional and easy to use. In addition, it is important to conduct user research and gather feedback throughout the design process to ensure that the product meets the needs and expectations of the target audience. (4)

At the same time, in small companies and agencies, this is most often done by universal specialists (UX & UI Designers). This approach can have advantages as it allows for a more

cohesive and efficient design process. Universal specialists are able to work on all aspects of the design from start to finish, ensuring consistency and a unified vision.

To answer the questions that the UX poses, designer needs to understand how the service works, what priorities the user has while using that product, what function and with which frequency he will use, and so on.

UI, in turn, can be considered an easier task, although it is not. Almost every solution can be subjective, although the task of the designer is to make it as easy to use, aesthetic and enjoyable as possible for the maximum number of users.

We can find articles and forums such as "Why you shouldn't hire a UX/UI designer" (5, 43), "Why a UI Designer is not a UX Designer" (43), which suggest that a person can't be good at several things at once, but in my personal experience and the experience of my colleagues, it can be concluded that in smaller agencies a UX & UI designer position is very popular, since it can save a lot of resources. However, it is important for these designers to still prioritize user research and feedback in order to create a user-friendly product (4, 5, 45).

1.2. User Interface Design

User interface (UI) refers to the visual and interactive components of a digital product that enable users to interact with it. It is a combination of content (documents, texts, images, videos, etc.), forms (buttons, labels, text fields, checkboxes, dropdowns, graphic design, etc.) and behavior (what happens if I click/drag/type). (6)

UI Design is focused on the "communication" of the product, the layout, typography, color scheme, and other design elements that make up the look and feel of the product. UI designers work to create an interface that is visually appealing, functional and easy to use, with a clear hierarchy of information and intuitive navigation. A well-designed user interface can definitely improve the user experience and the success of a service.

Either way, even if it is different from UX design, they share a common goal: to make the user's experience as great as possible.

1.3. Design process

Returning to the main topic, UX design concerns itself with the overall experience that a user has when interacting with a product or service. This involves understanding the user's needs, goals, and behaviors, and designing a smooth and enjoyable experience that meets those needs. The process includes user research, user flows, structure, information architecture, wireframing, prototyping, and testing.

Design thinking is a human-centered approach to problem-solving that involves empathy, creativity, and iteration. It places a strong emphasis on understanding user demands while developing customized solutions that meet those needs. Both approaches (UX Design and Design Thinking) require a deep understanding of the user and their context, and both require designers to be creative and flexible in their problem-solving approach.

According to the Stanford School of Design, the design thinking process involves several stages, including empathizing with the user, defining the problem, ideating potential solutions, prototyping and testing those solutions, and iterating based on user feedback (7). Nick Babich, in his article "The UX Design Process: Everything You Need to Know," proposes a slightly different approach with five stages: product definition, research, analysis, design, and validation (8).

Personally, I am comfortable with the slightly more detailed approach to design that we have been using at work, which includes the following steps:

- **Understanding.** Includes an understanding of the task, brief, goals that the team faces. At the same time, understanding (empathy) users and their needs, creating user personas, defining use cases and scenarios. this is a very important stage, because without understanding the problem by the design team, the product can rarely be successful or go in the right direction.
- **Research.** This can involve surveys, internal and external interviews, usability tests, to gather data on user behavior and preferences; market analytics, competition analysis, trend report and other research method. Once research is complete, designers analyze the data to gain insights and identify opportunities for improving the user experience (41).
- **Sketching / Prototyping.** Based on the insights gained during the research and analysis, it includes gathering ideas, team suggestions, creating wireframes, mockups, and prototypes that demonstrate the proposed design solution (for instance, low-fidelity wireframes that don't take long). Thus, the team can prepare several options for solving the problem at once, immediately proceed to the testing stage, and decide on the final version for implementation.
- **Design.** Includes product design itself, high-fidelity prototyping, creating branding and guidelines - this is the stage where UI Design is involved.
- **Testing.** In this phase, the design is tested with users to identify any usability issues or areas for improvement. Testing can take many forms, including usability tests, A/B tests, and user surveys (9).
- **Implementing.** Refinement of the UI guidelines and product implementation. During implementation, designers work closely with developers to ensure that the design is translated accurately into the final product.

- **Evaluation.** The final step in the UX design process is to evaluate the success of the design solution. This can involve getting feedback from the users, further testing and audits, viewing analytics.

Design process is one of an iterative methods of creating a good product, which consists of several stages. It is possible to do them one by one and then come back indefinitely.

The user experience design process, being iterative and ongoing, is important, because it helps to ensure that digital products are designed with the user in mind. By following a user-centered design process, designers can create products that are more usable, effective, and satisfying and are more likely to be successful and achieve the desired outcomes for the business (10).

1.4. Modern tools for UX/UI design of mobile applications

As of today, there are a large number of applications and services that designers can use in their work. Some of them combine several directions (e.g., visual design and interactive prototyping), and some are more narrowly focused (e.g., Miro for collaborative work).

Designers can use them for wireframing, sketching, prototyping, user testing, and communication both within the team and with the client or user. Overall, the choice depends on personal preferences, project requirements, budget, and team collaboration (42).

I will briefly review some popular design tools.

1.4.1 Figma

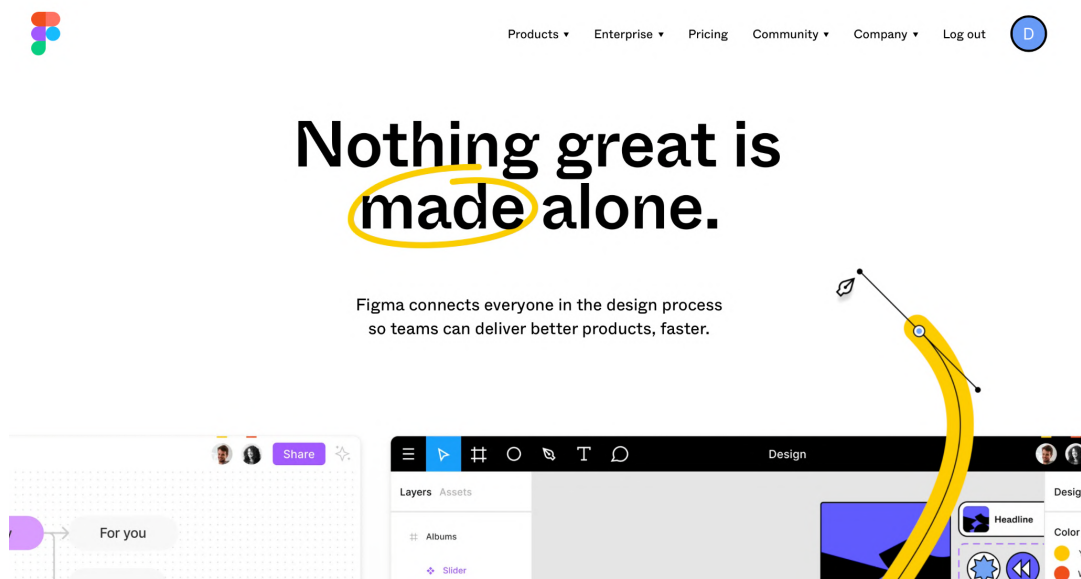


Figure 1 Figma, 2023 (© 2023 Figma.com)

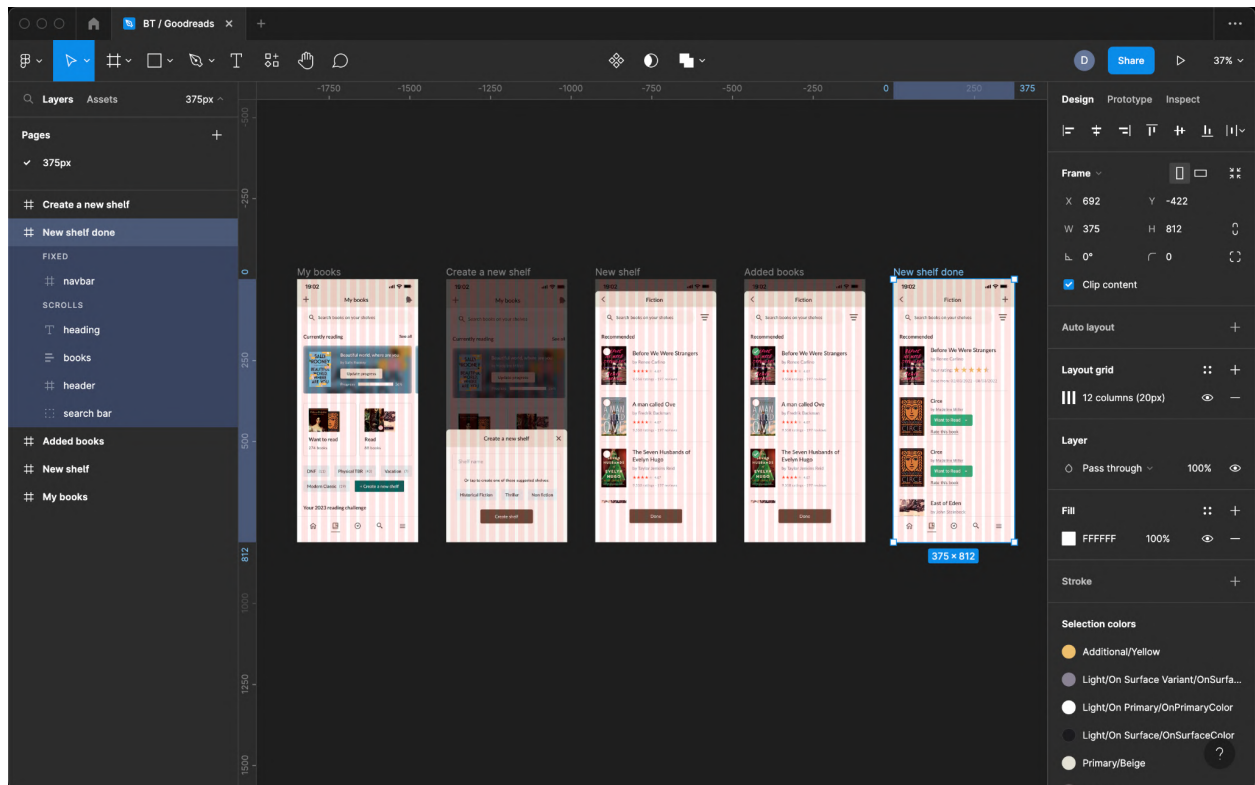


Figure 2 Figma Interface, 2023

[Figma](#) is a cloud-based design tool and graphical online editor that allows designers to collaborate in real-time. It offers a range of features for designing interfaces and prototypes for mobile applications, including built-in design components and vector editing tools. It is perfect for collaboration as it allows to discuss edits with multiple colleagues in real time or sync up the progress. Figma is also quite comfortable to use with No-code services such as Webflow. Figma as well has a large library of plugins that can be used to extend the functionality of the tool.

It is mostly free for individual use and has become very popular in recent years.

I have been working in Figma for several years now. For the practical part of my thesis, I have chosen to use this tool as it is accessible, intuitive, visually appealing, and has interactive prototyping features. This tool also includes design components that I will review in more detail in another section of the thesis.

1.4.2. Adobe XD

[Adobe XD](#) is a part of the Adobe Creative Cloud and serves as a universal platform for creating wireframes, website designs, mobile applications, voice interfaces, and more. Adobe XD facilitates cross-platform collaboration in real-time, allowing teams to receive valuable feedback directly from customers.

Although Adobe XD also offers plugins, its library is not as extensive as Figma's.

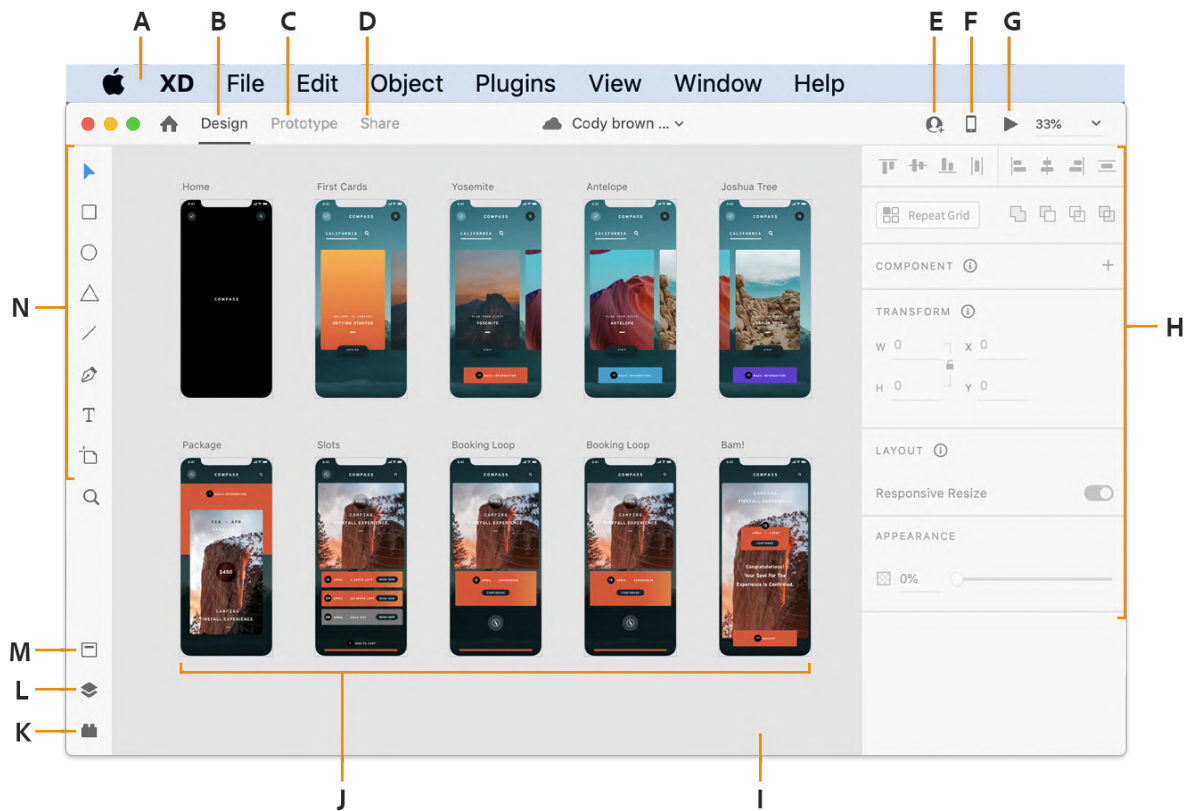


Figure 3 Adobe XD, 2023 (© 2023 Adobe.com)

1.4.3. Sketch

[Sketch](#) is one of the most widely used UI and prototyping software programs among millions of programmers worldwide. It is a tool similar to Figma, but is only available for iOS (11). While some designers note that Figma is a cloud-based program and that Sketch's response time is a fraction of a second faster, I did not notice such a significant difference. Therefore, I prefer Figma, which is more common in 2022 and is also free.

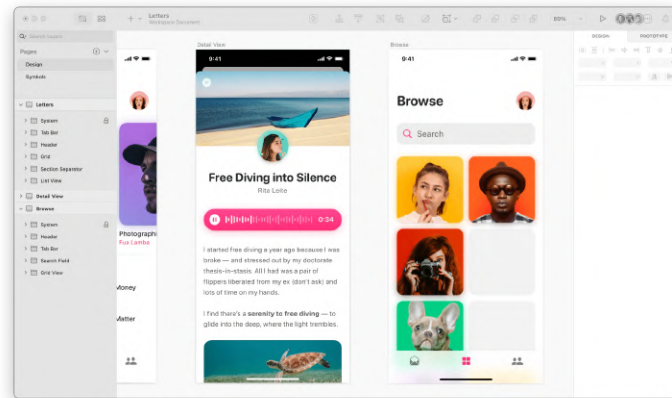


Figure 4 Sketch (© 2023 Sketch B.V.)

1.4.4. InVision

[InVision](#) is a cloud-based service for designing and prototyping web and mobile apps. With InVision, teams can collaborate to create functional prototypes with interactive elements.

InVision offers several tools, including a brainstorming board, an interactive prototyping tool, and a collaborative platform for generating and discussing ideas. It provides a blank canvas where users can draw together, take notes, comment on each other's ideas, and insert images.

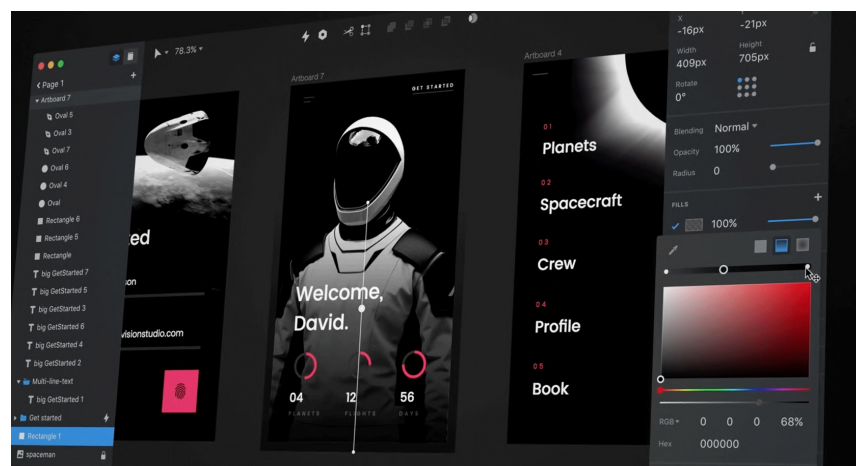


Figure 5 InVision (Toptal, LLC © 2010-2023)

1.4.5. Marvel

[Marvel](#) is a great design platform for non-designers. It is especially useful during the creative process or as an addition to other vector editors. Marvel's animation features are very convenient, allowing you to create and customize transitions, change layouts if necessary, and view a prototype on a smartphone.

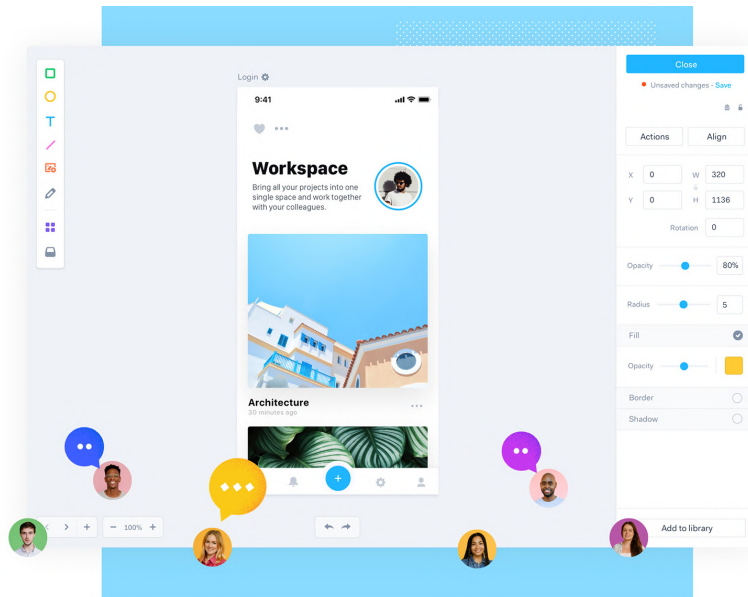


Figure 6 Marvel (Marvel Prototyping Ltd., 2023)

1.4.6. Miro

[Miro](#) (formerly RealtimeBoard) is a platform for remote collaboration using an online whiteboard. The board is suitable for drafting, creativity, design concepts, brainstorming and educational purposes. It allows to add downloaded files and documents to the board, draw, take notes and insert post-its. There are many premade templates available, such as Flowchart, User Surveys, and Customer Touchpoint Map.

Users can collaborate using text, voice, or video chat, as well as share content and view the board in real-time.

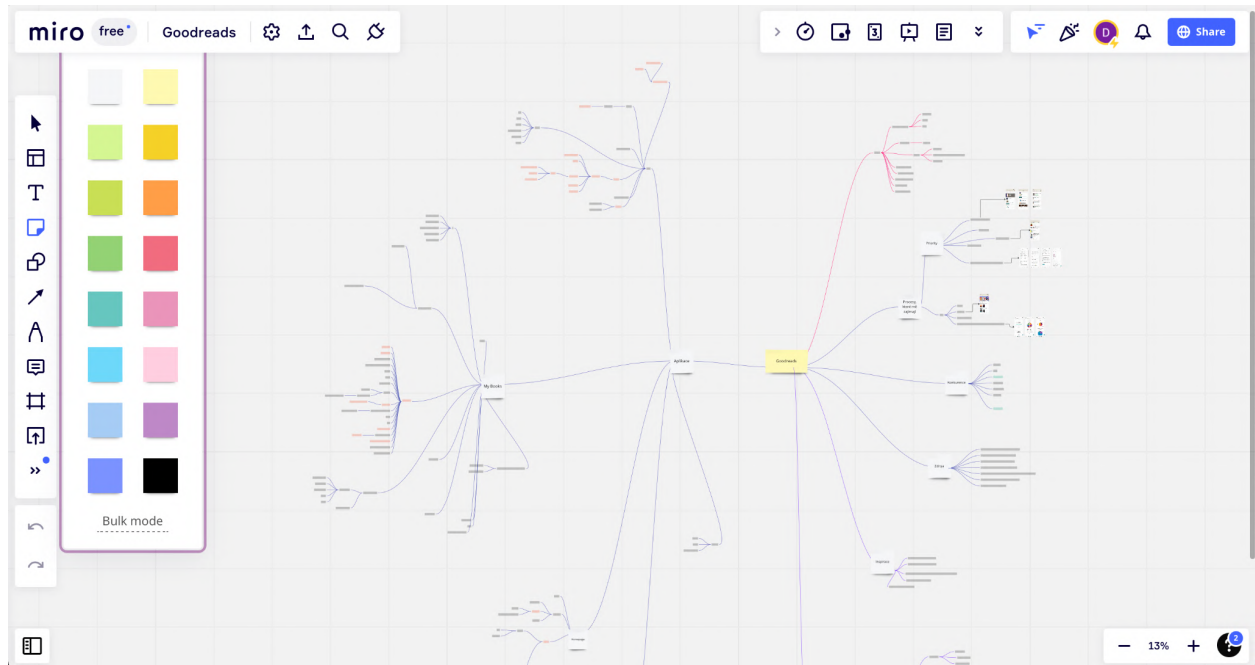


Figure 7 Miro, 2023

1.4.7. Conclusion

For my thesis, I will be using Figma for wireframing, design, and interactive prototyping, and Miro for creating scenarios, project orientation, and testing.

I chose to use Figma because I have been using it for almost four years and am familiar with it from work. It is free, has auto-layouts, components, and great interactive prototypes, all of which are features that I will utilize for this project. An added bonus of Figma for me is its Community section, where I can easily find icons, components, plugins, and UI Kits.

Miro is intuitive, user-friendly, and can be used for a range of design tasks at different stages of the design process, from brainstorming and ideation to wireframing and user journey mapping.

1.5. Prototyping

The main purpose of a prototype is to provide a visual representation of what the final product will look like.

Prototypes not only visualize an idea but also allow for the following tasks:

- Check the viability of an idea and evaluate its prospects to understand how much demand there is for the product among users.
- Significantly reduce design development time, simplify technical development, and ultimately lower the cost of the entire project.
- Accelerate the launch of startups and attract investors by providing a clear view of where the money will be invested.
- Identify problem areas early on and make changes instead of tracking them during development and spending time and money on fixes.
- Serve as a reference document for customers to verify completed work, ensuring that the result meets the approved project.
- Conduct preliminary tests and analyze the behavior of the target audience to understand which functions are convenient and which are not.
- Help estimate the cost of project implementation, as it is immediately visible what technology stack is needed, how many specialists will be needed, and how quickly they can implement the idea (12).

Overall, prototypes are needed to present the project to the customer and evaluate its usability. Prototype testing allows to identify and fix bugs early on, before investing in final design and code (12, 13).

In this chapter, i will examine several basic types of prototyping, which mainly differ in detail.

1.5.1. Paper Prototype or Sketches

This is the simplest way to create a prototype. It involves developing behavioral scenarios (also called "client paths") by clearly understanding the location of interface elements (14). This could just be a sheet of paper on which the main components of the site structure are drawn by hand. Sketches are very easy to modify and save time, but they don't look professional and don't allow for editing an existing design.



Figure 8 Paper prototype (© 2010-2023 UXPin Sp. z o.o.)

1.5.3. Low-Fidelity prototypes

Similar to paper sketches, digital prototypes allow for the creation of visual representations of designs, and can be made using specialized prototyping programs such as Figma or Adobe XD.

The purpose of such a prototype is to demonstrate the overall composition, placement, and quantity of design elements. As a result, they are often created using black and white colors.

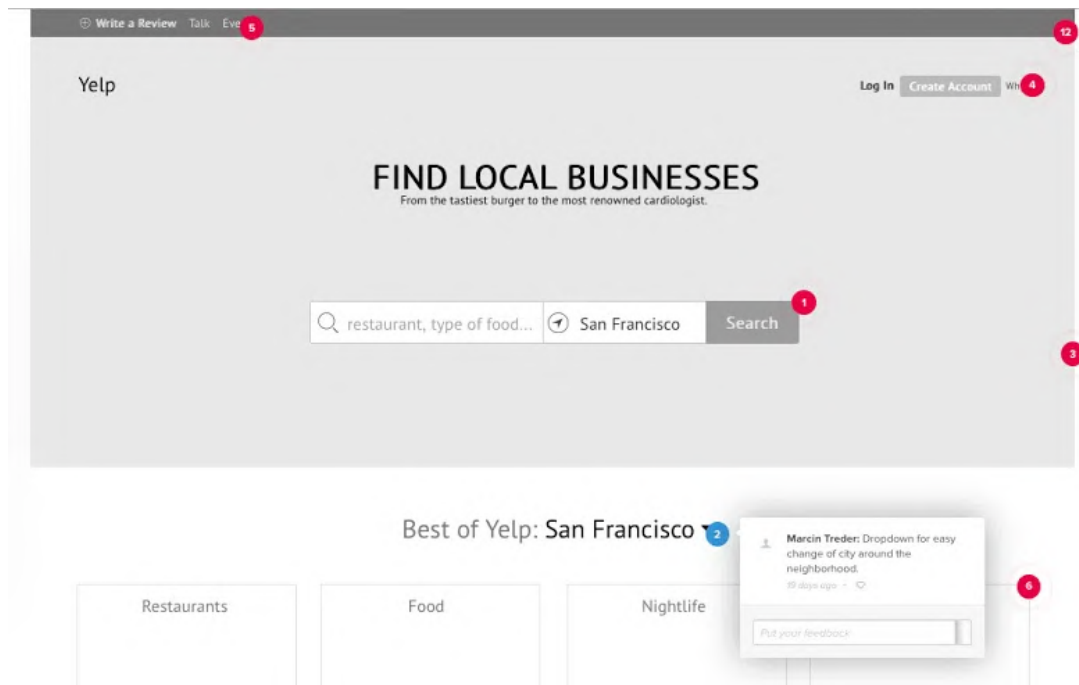


Figure 9 Low-fidelity prototype (© 2010-2023 UXPin Sp. z o.o.)

1.5.4. High-Fidelity prototypes

High-fidelity prototypes are typically used in the final stage of prototyping to showcase all functional elements of the future interface. They include icons, graphics, typography, and sometimes shadows and images.

This allows the customer to approve and the developer to evaluate the complexity of the interface and its features as accurately as possible.

High-fidelity prototypes resemble finished pages, but might be monochrome.

One disadvantage is that creating a high-detail site prototype requires a significant amount of time, but it is much more useful because it provides a more realistic representation of the final product and allows for more thorough testing of functionality and usability.

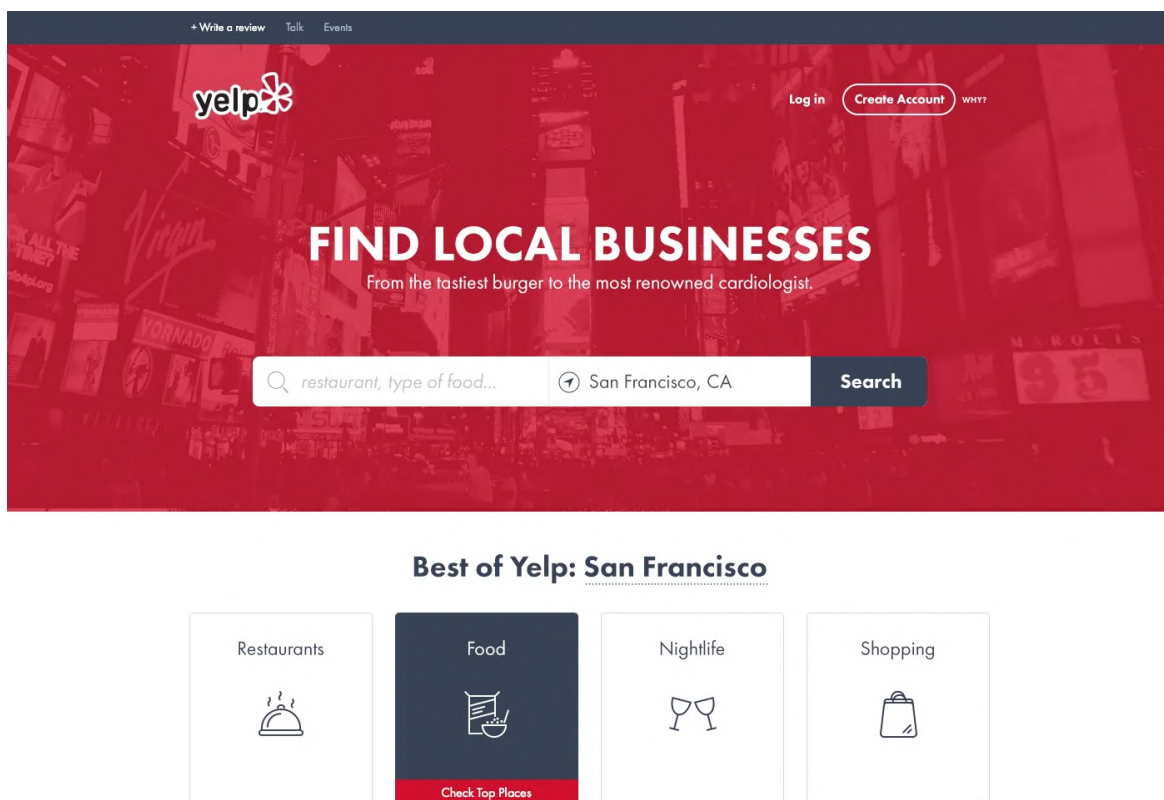


Figure 10 High-fidelity prototype (© 2010-2023 UXPin Sp. z o.o.)

1.5.5. Interactive prototypes

An interactive prototype is a series of linked pages that simulate the basic interactions of a website's interface. Examples of these interactions include drop-down menus, block switching, slider usage, and data processing.

Interactive prototypes resemble fully functional resources, and their purpose is to test and evaluate the usability of the interface at an early stage, so that errors can be identified and corrected.

Therefore, the various benefits of prototyping include the ability to save time and money, simplify technical development, reduce the overall cost of the project, and more. By creating a prototype, designers can also help launch startups faster and find investors, as they can clearly demonstrate where the money is being invested.

In my case, wireframes and an interactive prototype will be necessary, as they will allow to visualize and explore potential changes to the application.

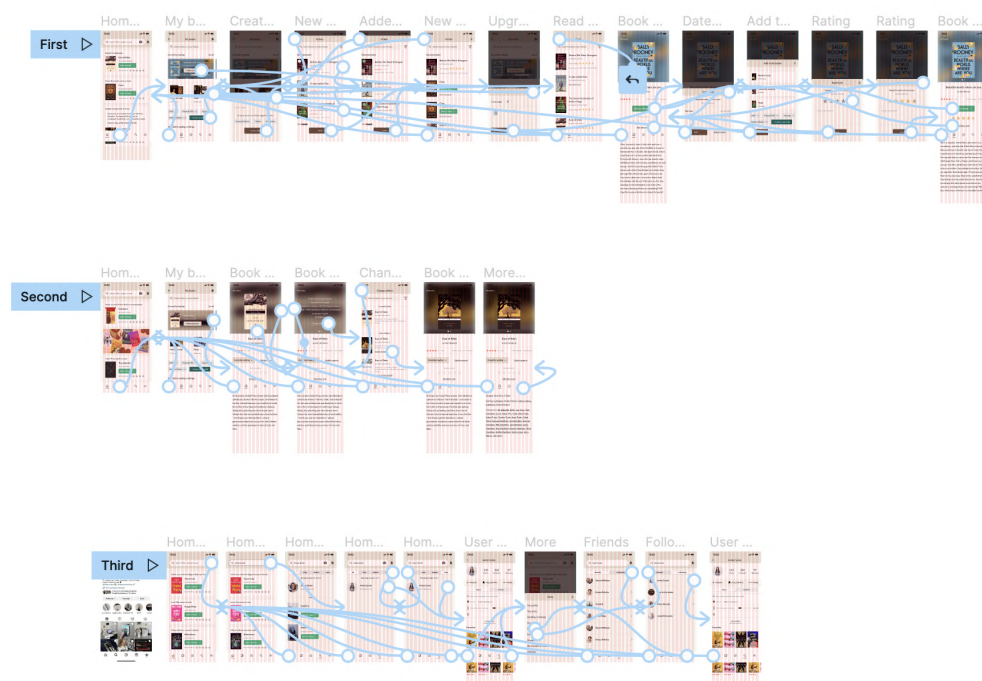


Figure 11 Interactive prototype in Figma, 2023

2. Digitalising the reader's user experience

Books have always played a significant role in social interaction, with readers often recommending their favorite titles to friends and family or discussing them in literature classes or book clubs. With the rise of social media, social behavior has changed, and reading has not

been left untouched. Nowadays, reading is a more interactive online experience, with e-books replacing physical books and Goodreads reviews replacing simple recommendations to friends.

2.1. Digital social reading

Social reading encompasses both offline and online activities. Offline activities include informal face-to-face discussions with friends, formal discussions in book clubs or literature circles (15; 16), and educational settings. With the development of digital and social media, online book clubs or reading communities (such as Goodreads) have become increasingly popular (17, 18; 19). These communities allow users to share their thoughts about a book in an online environment, comment on specific paragraphs or sentences (20), highlight and share them, and interact with other users.

In 2003, Rehberg Sedo conducted a survey (21) on reading in social groups, which involved a 34-question survey posted online and promoted through personal and professional email lists, as well as message boards and email lists of reading groups. It gathered responses from a diverse group of participants from 13 different forums, including Yahoo.com and the New York Times reading group's bulletin board. The survey received 252 responses during the two-week period in June and July 2001. The survey found that members of online book clubs described their experience as "global intimacy" (21, 22), meaning that they felt connected to others worldwide based on common interests through communication such as likes and comments.

Therefore, it is likely that online book communities, such as Goodreads, will continue to grow in popularity and importance in the future.

Given that Covid-19 has already partially erased the boundaries between online and offline user experiences (23), we can conclude that online book communities can fully replace well-known book clubs or offline discussion groups.

2.2. Goodreads

Goodreads is the world's largest website for readers and book recommendations (24). Users can browse books by genre, rate them, post and share reviews, add other users as friends, and discuss what they read in groups. Additionally, users can create shelves for their favorite books, make a "Want to read" list, subscribe to favorite authors, receive individual recommendations, or participate in challenges.

2.2.1. Company profile

Goodreads was founded in December 2006 and launched in January 2007 by Otis Chandler and Elizabeth Khuri Chandler. By 2013, the site had 16 million members, at which point it was purchased by Amazon for an undisclosed sum. By July 2019, the site had 90 million members. The website's offices are located in San Francisco (25, 26).

Goodreads offers both a mobile and web application. The website underwent a redesign in recent years, resulting in a more modern and user-friendly interface. The web application is responsive, and I have drawn inspiration from its design in the practical part, for example creating the book detail page.

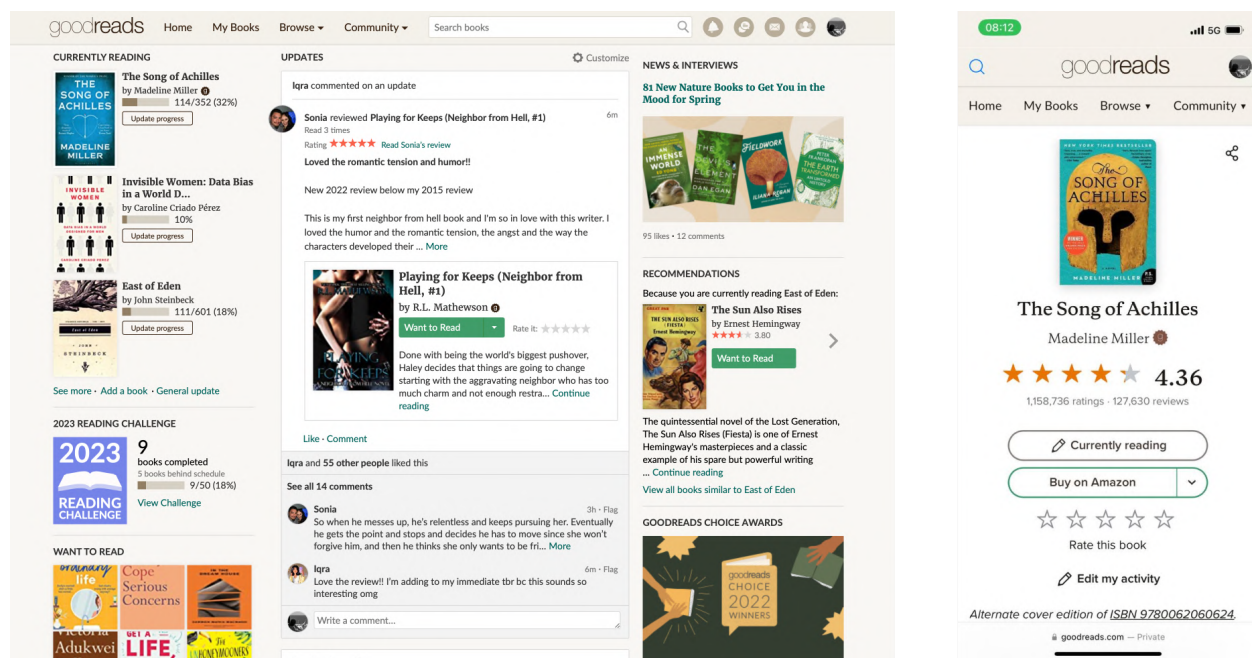


Figure 12 Goodreads.com, 2023

2.2.2. App

Goodreads is a completely free app available for both Android and iOS. As of September 2022, the app is ranked #5 in the Books category on the App Store with a score of 4.8 and over 439k ratings (2). On Google Play, the application has 134k reviews with an average score of 3.6 (27).

One of its key features is that it does not include any in-app purchases, which is great for users who do not want to spend money on additional features. However, it is important to note that the app can be synced with Amazon's Kindle app, which offers a wide range of books and a Kindle Unlimited Subscription that require payment.

In general, the application is one big table of data that can be exported to a .csv file and imported into other applications. For example, it is very convenient to transfer a library to The StoryGraph.

This app is also very handy for anyone who has an Amazon Kindle e-reader. It allows immediate synchronization of the progress of a book, marking as "currently reading," rating after reading, and other features. However, some users may experience certain issues when using the Kindle app. For example, the progress of a book didn't update when I read it on Kindle, and I had to update it myself for "friends" in the app to see my current progress and for me to leave my notes. Additionally, sometimes when I marked a book as currently reading on the Kindle, the progress bar on the app disappeared entirely on my phone. Finally, the Kindle app does not show the saved "Want to read" list from Goodreads, requiring to use phone to select new books to purchase.

2.2.5. Direct competition - applications for readers

As discussed in the "Digital social reading" section, most platforms are created for readers to communicate with other users who share the same interests. Some platforms offer additional features, such as tracking books read, conducting quizzes and polls, an annual reading challenge, or detailed reading statistics for the year.

When searching for direct competition to Goodreads, I found that there are very few alternatives. Apart from The StoryGraph, there are almost no other similar applications. There are sites with book recommendations, sites for discussing books, and book trackers, but few applications that combine all these functions. This lack of competition may be one reason why the Goodreads app has not significantly improved over the years, as there is little motivation for Amazon to make changes.

The main advantage of other applications is that their companies/developers respond to user feedback and make improvements, while Goodreads has not been as responsive. For example, users have long requested a half-star rating system (allowing for the rating of books with 4.5 stars, for instance), a "DNF" (did not finish) button, and the ability to add the category "book I own" by default (currently only possible by creating a new shelf). (28)

In this section, I will examine the most popular online reading services, based on their user base, customer reviews, and ratings and reviews on the App Store and Google Play.

2.2.2.1. The Storygraph

[The StoryGraph](#) is a popular reading app that functions as a reading tracker. It is considered to be Goodreads' main competitor, as it offers an almost identical platform. Users can set goals for

themselves in terms of the number of books or pages read, as well as follow friends to see what they are reading and what reviews they have left.

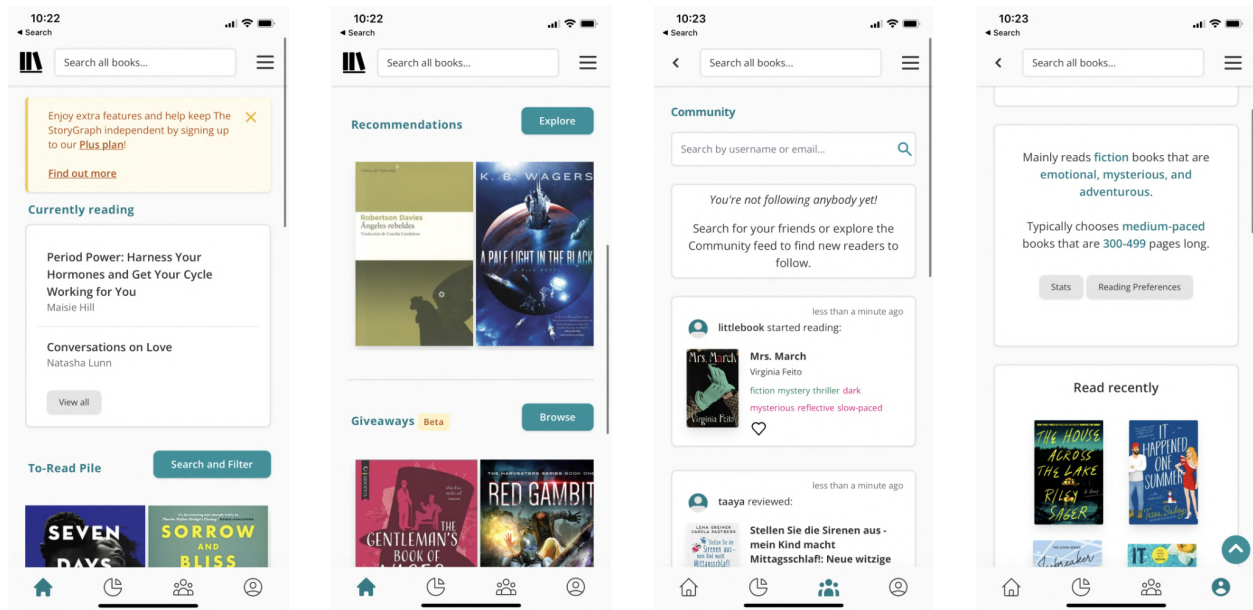


Figure 13 The StoryGraph, 2023

The application is developed by an independent developer, and new features are added with each update.

In recent years, many YouTube and Tiktok influencers have recommended switching to The StoryGraph as a reading tracker alternative (46, 47, 48). However, the main reason for this switch is not just that it offers an alternative to Goodreads, but rather an alternative to Amazon, which is attempting to monopolize the book market (29, 30).

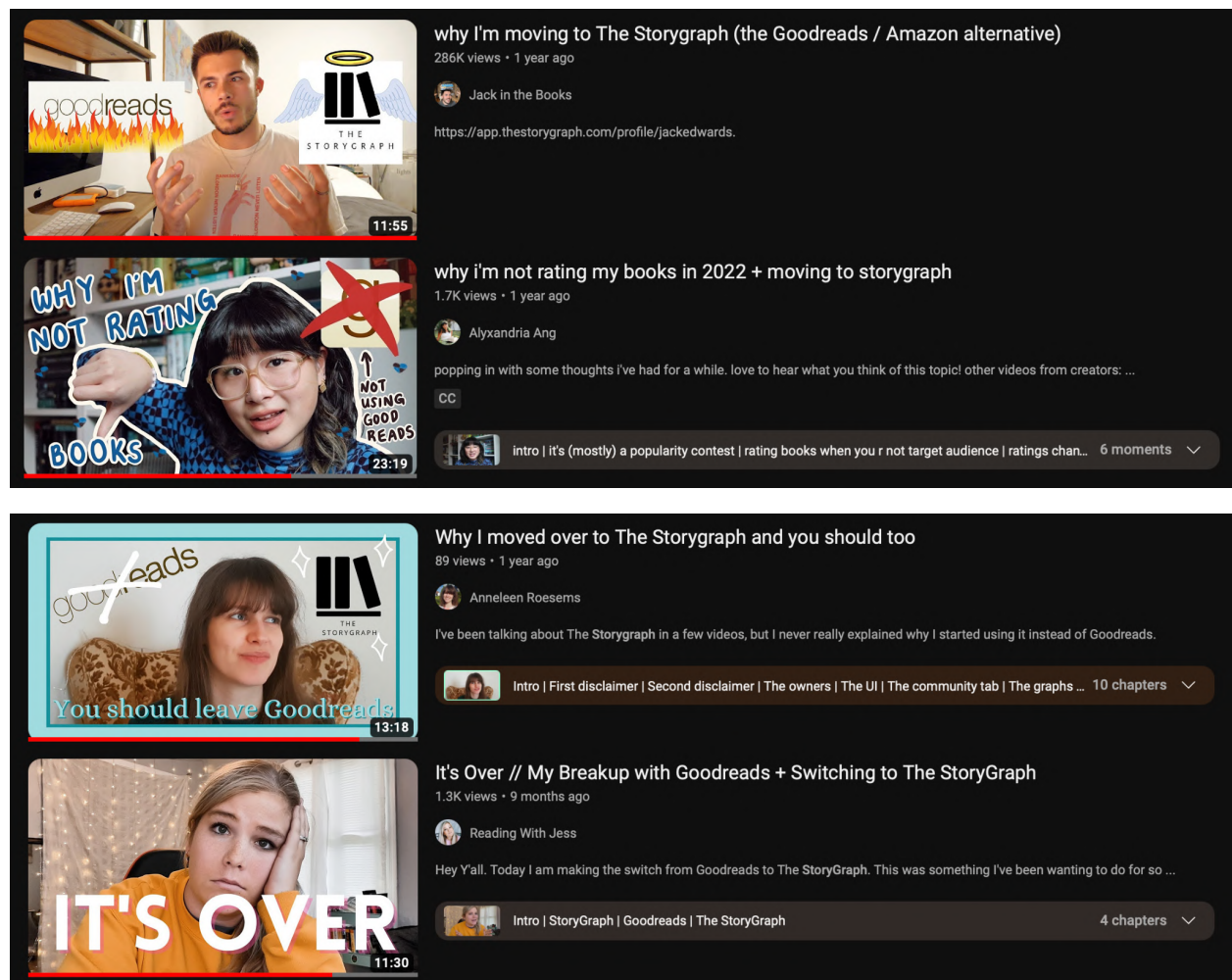


Figure 14 Screenshot from YouTube. Search result for “Why I’m leaving Goodreads”, 2022

Goodreads has a wider audience and is more popular, which means it has more reviews and ratings. It is also more interactive and easy to find "friends", making its "stream" look more active.

On the other hand, The StoryGraph has a much more modern and cleaner look, although after using it for half a year, I wouldn't say it's a great application in terms of UX and UI. Its main advantage is individual detailed reading statistics presented in charts, graphs, and tables, featuring themes, genres, and moods. Being part of the target audience, I have used The StoryGraph for half a year solely to track my statistics, while continuing to use Goodreads for the community and reviews.

The StoryGraph allows users to "DNF" (did not finish) a book, identify what they like and don't like, and filter recommendations and lists with different criteria as their reading mood changes (28). When reviewing a book, The StoryGraph asks about its mood, pace, whether it's plot- or character-driven, level of character development, how lovable and diverse the characters are, and whether or not the flaws of the characters are a main focus. Responses to these questions

are averaged and tabulated on each book's landing page, providing a more comprehensive view of what it's actually like to read the title, rather than just presenting a basic summary (31). Additionally, The StoryGraph allows users to set their own star ratings, such as giving a book a 3.5 or 4.75 star rating.

While still a relatively new application with a smaller audience, The StoryGraph is the main competition for Goodreads and has the potential to replace it in the future.

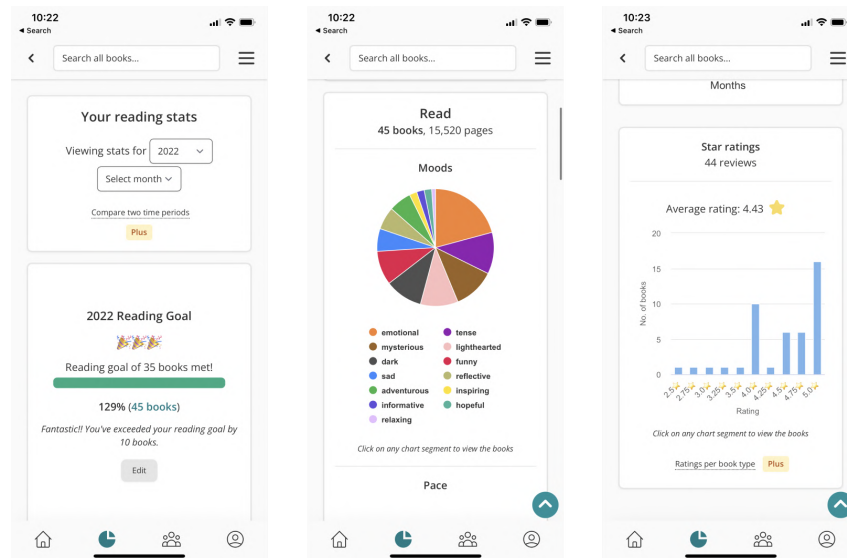


Figure 15 Personal reading stats on The StoryGraph, 2023

2.2.2.2. BookSloth

[BookSloth](#) is a mobile app that focuses on the community and communication among book lovers, as well as providing browsing recommendations. Compared to Goodreads, the app has a cleaner and more modern look, making it more appealing to younger readers. However, despite its unique features, BookSloth is not as well-known in the reading community as other apps like Goodreads (32).

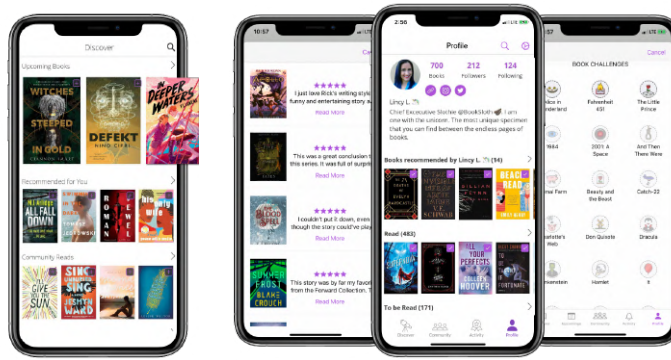


Figure 16 BookSloth (© 2018 BookSloth, Inc)

2.2.2.3. Wattpad

[Wattpad](#) is a free online community for readers and writers, as well as Goodreads. It allows to find friends with similar interests, read stories by other authors, write your own "fanfiction", create reading lists, rate stories, and save content.

However, unlike Goodreads, Wattpad also allows you to write and share your own stories. Goodreads is mainly a tracking and database app for books, rather than a storytelling platform.

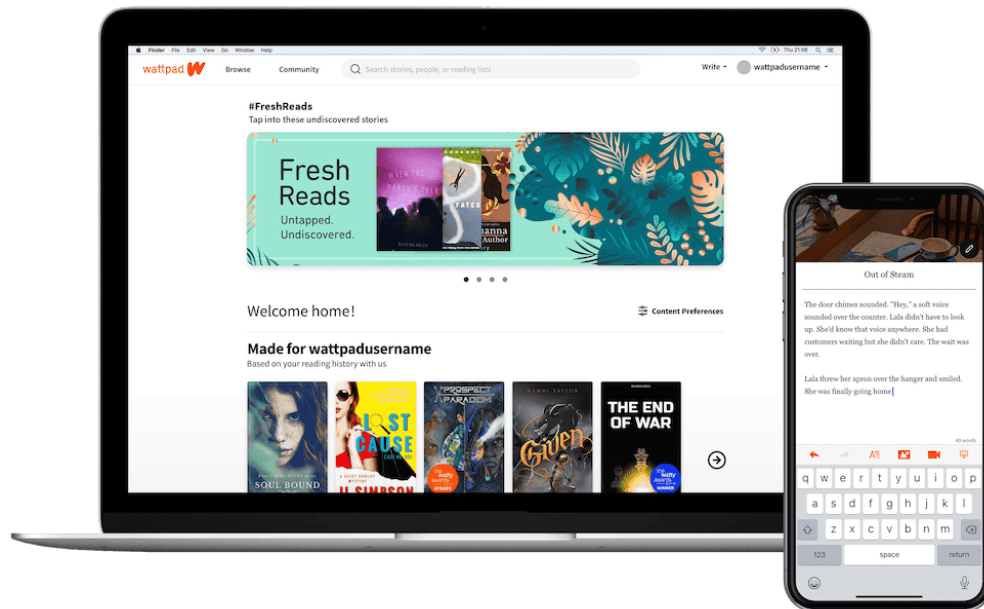


Figure 17 Wattpad (© 2023 Wattpad)

2.2.2.4. Bookly

[Bookly](#) is a tool designed to help users keep track of their reading habits. It provides detailed statistics and progress reports, aiming to keep users motivated and focused on their reading goals.

Features include tracking the number of hours and days that the user has read, their reading speed, and reading challenges.



Figure 18 Bookly (© Bookly® 2023)

2.2.6. Indirect competition

In this section, I will examine the indirect competition faced by the Goodreads application, such as online libraries and the Letterboxd app. Although the latter may, at first glance, appear unrelated to books, books and films are both important parts of our society and have a similar target audience.

2.2.6.1. Online libraries

Electronic book services have revolutionized the way we read books. They are more convenient, environmentally-friendly, and save money in the long run. Surely, they provide access from any device, such as a phone or tablet. These services also make it easier to find the “right” book through individual recommendations, selections, and reviews.

Many of these services operate on the principle of a "book Netflix." This means that users pay a fixed monthly fee to access an unlimited number of available books through subscription. This method is ideal for avid readers who enjoy reading multiple books per month. However, it may not be the most cost-effective option for readers who prefer to read only 1-2 books in a month. In such cases, it may be more economical to buy books without subscribing to any service. The

most popular services include [Scribd](#), [Bookmate](#), [Kindle](#), [Libby](#), and [Audible](#), an online audiobook library. Some services offer a limited selection of books for free, while others require a monthly subscription fee ranging from \$10 to \$15. Many of them also offer a 30-day trial period.

2.2.6.2. Letterboxd

[Letterboxd](#) and Goodreads are social media platforms that focus on sharing and discovering information based on interests. However, the primary difference between the two platforms is the type of content they feature. Goodreads is a platform for book lovers, where users can share book reviews, ratings, and recommendations. On the other hand, Letterboxd is a platform for movie and TV show enthusiasts, where users can share reviews and ratings, follow other users, and browse individual recommendations for films and TV shows.

Despite their similar features, they have different user interfaces. Goodreads has a cluttered and text-heavy interface, while Letterboxd is more visually oriented, featuring posters, stills, and trailers for movies and TV shows.

Both platforms have mobile apps in addition to their desktop versions. The Letterboxd mobile app has received positive reviews for its user-friendly design and features.

Another difference between Goodreads and Letterboxd is the social aspect of the platforms. Goodreads encourages users to join groups and participate in discussions, while Letterboxd focuses more on following other users and their reviews. Additionally, Letterboxd allows users to create lists of movies and TV shows, as well as mark them as watched or to-watch.

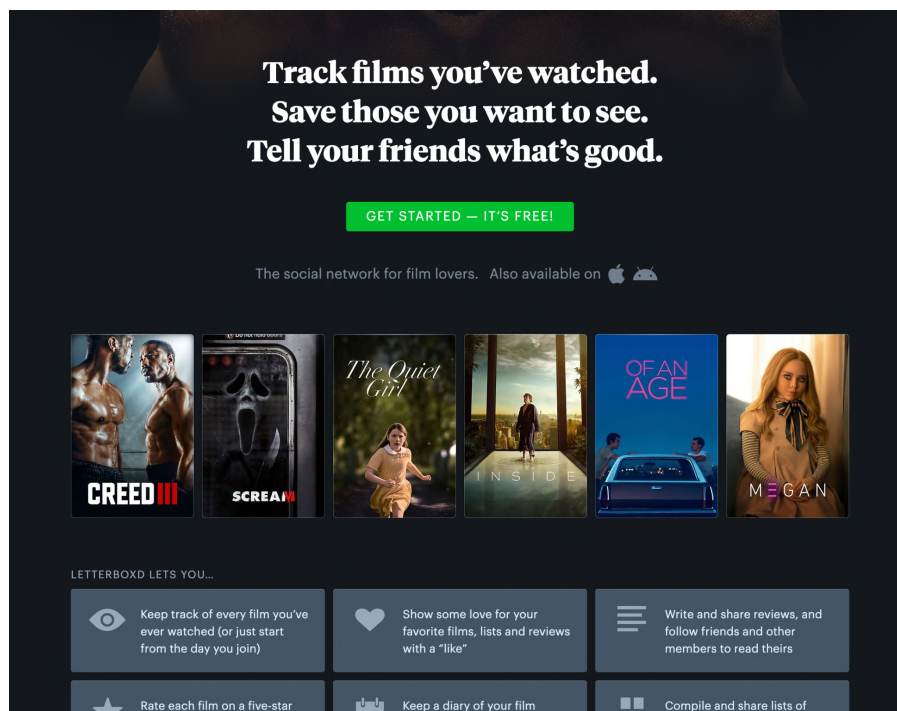


Figure 19 Letterboxd (© Letterboxd Limited 2023)

2.2.7. Conclusion

Given the above, the main problem of Goodreads may be the lack of direct qualitative competition, which may be the reason for its slow development over the years. The StoryGraph stands out as the main alternative due to its detailed reading statistics, more responsive developers and modern look, but it still has a smaller audience compared to Goodreads. Other alternatives include BookSloth, Wattpad, and Bookly. Indirect competition comes from online libraries and social media platforms such as Letterboxd. The biggest strength of Goodreads remains its large community, possibility for authors to promote their books and engage with authors and its popularity.

Practical part

3. Research

Goodreads was founded in December 2006 and launched in January 2007 (1). It has been around for 15 years, which is quite a long time. As of the beginning of 2021, Goodreads boasted more than 90 million members - an impressive feat and proof that the portal has stood the test of time (49).

However, there have not been any major changes to the website's functionality during this time. Despite complaints from many users about the lack of innovation, there has been little impact on the site's popularity. (33)

I chose this topic because the service is incredibly popular and I use it daily as a reader. As a UX designer, I also notice many areas for improvement within the application. These issues are visible not only to designers, but also to regular users, as may be seen in the App Store or book community. Unfortunately, these concerns often go unnoticed.

It is surprising how users write long and angry reviews and still give the app a 4 or 5-star rating.

4.1. User satisfaction analysis

During my research, I came across some articles and Goodreads user surveys that were quite helpful for my thesis. For instance, these included "Almost Everything About Goodreads Is Broken" by Angela Lashbrook (34) and "6 Reasons Why You Should Stop Using Goodreads" by Simona Tolcheva (33).

I also reviewed user feedback from the App store, Google Play, and within the app itself. Here are some selected reviews that better illustrate the situation with the application.

4.1.1. App store & Google Play reviews



peytonlam, 01/22/2023

Great if you're willing to give up some time!

The 2 stars I'm giving you is to get your attention. Your app is wonderful, and honestly, is one of only 2 on my iPhone that has (till now) been basically trouble-free. I use it all the time, and find it easy to use/intuitive, timely and filled with excellent information, (true story). Thanks for a great product.



donaldrumpslefttoe, 05/15/2021

Hi Goodreads. PLEASE ADD THESE THINGS

This app is wonderful. It is almost perfect. BUT every person I've talked to who uses Goodreads have all been in agreement it would be a GAME CHANGER if these were added:

- 1) A 0.5 star option. It sounds silly but it can be so frustrating deciding if a book is 4 or 5 stars. If there was a 4.5 option for example, I think all my life problems would be solved.
- 2) Private ratings. I'm sure if you're an app developer you know of Letterboxd, and for me personally, if some similar features could be added to Goodreads that would make it just "chef's kiss". For example: one of my favorite things about Letterboxd is how your ratings don't account to a larger average rating for a movie (but in this case it would be a book). You can rate a movie and write your OWN review describing how that movie fit into your personal taste. I would love to see this on Goodreads in a way in which I could do a private review (almost like a personal diary) rather than a public rating. Sometimes I'll read a book and recognize it's objectively a great book, but I might give it two stars because maybe that sub-genre of fantasy romance wasn't up my alley, so maybe that review would be nice to have in a personal journal rather than a public one because my review is sort of niche. I hope this makes sense. :))) I LOVE THIS APP!!!

needs a revamp

I use this app religiously but it needs a revamp BAD. The UI looks like it hasn't changed since day 1 and it'd be nice if I could see my friends' activity more often than I see ads on my feed 😊. Would be nice if we could personalize our profiles, but not necessary. Also, recommendations or searching through genres could be greatly enhanced by further filtering of intended audiences—I don't want to scroll through twenty 20 children's fantasy books before even finding one mediocre adult fantasy book I'm not interested in. ABSOLUTELY would benefit from half star rating system or even 10 star rating system instead of seeing a 3 star review with "3.5 stars ..." or a 1 star review with "0.5 stars..." in the actual review. The app is also not super user friendly and is generally clunky. Lots of unnecessary tapping needed and I don't know what it is but the searching function is super clunky too. I feel like the search option should first search our shelves for matches before searching the rest of the database for matches. Definitely need a multi-select option to make shelving multiple books easier. I have over 300 books in my read I'm not reshelving each individual book, Jeffrey. Add tags in reviews so we can filter by tags. Basically more filtering options for everything. Add private reviews only your friends can see so that they don't affect the overall review of the book (sometimes you can acknowledge a book is well-written and still hate it).



the ink wyrm, 12/17/2021

Good but could use some improvements

Overall, I think this is a decent app for tracking your reading progress (though by no means the only one in its category). The process of finding a book, adding it to your shelf, tracking its progress, and leaving a review is simple and easy. It's when you spend a little more time on it that I think it could use improvement. I've included my complaints/suggestions below in order from most to least important.

- 1.) The thing that I find most annoying about this app is that when I go to edit down my want-to-read shelf, it constantly refreshes the page even if I'm not actually removing a book from it. Like I'll click a book just to remind myself what it's about, and when I click to go back to the shelf, it will refresh the page and I'll have to scroll back down to where I was. It's both annoying and inefficient to constantly have to be scrolling down the shelf to find my place (especially because I have A LOT).
- 2.) Shelf won't load beyond a certain point if you have a lot of books.
- 3.) If I've DNF'd a book, there's no option but to add it to my read shelf, even if I add it to my separate DNF shelf.
- 4.) Adding a book to want to read shelf as part of a giveaway.



raema00, 11/29/2021

needs a revamp

I use this app religiously but it needs a revamp BAD. The UI looks like it hasn't changed since day 1 and it'd be nice if I could see my friends' activity more often than I see ads on my feed 😊. Would be nice if we could personalize our profiles, but not necessary. Also, recommendations or searching through genres could be greatly enhanced by further filtering of intended audiences—I don't want to scroll through twenty 20 children's fantasy books before even finding one mediocre adult fantasy book I'm not interested in. ABSOLUTELY would benefit from half star rating system or even 10 star rating system instead of seeing a 3 star review with "3.5 stars ..." or a 1 star review with "0.5 stars..." in the actual review. The app is also not super user friendly and is generally clunky. Lots of unnecessary tapping needed and I don't know what it is but the searching function is super clunky too. I feel like the search option should first search our shelves for matches before searching the rest of the database for matches. Definitely need a multi-select option to make shelving multiple books easier. I have over 300 books in my read I'm not reshelving each individual book, Jeffrey. Add tags in reviews so we can filter by tags. Basically more filtering options for everything. Add private reviews only your friends can see so that they don't affect the overall review of the book (sometimes you can acknowledge a book is well-written and still hate it).

★★★☆☆ February 19, 2023

If you don't have this app already, don't get it! I am only still here because I've been known Goodreads for a decade. Pretty sure none of the infrastructure of Goodreads has been updated for a decade, either. I am having been trying to unfollow one annoying and overactive author for *years* on both the desktop and phone app, and he still shows up in my feed (I'm not the only one with this kind of issue). It's awkward and not intuitive. It's just a place to keep a list of books you've read, that's it.

★★★☆☆ January 16, 2023

I love this app! However, it would be so much better if it had the functionality to mark books as being re-read. It's unfortunate that if I want to re-read a favorite classic, it doesn't leave it in the Read pile and erases the record of it having been read before. It's very frustrating. Also, there needs to be an option for audiobooks. Goodreads is owned by Amazon but I can't add most of my audible books to my list to differentiate paper copies from audiobooks? Again, very frustrating.

★★★★★ January 9, 2023

Great for reading reviews, recommendations, keeping track of everything. The whole idea behind the app is great and honestly keeps me motivated to read. However, it's got some pretty big software and UI issues. Adding friends for example is embarrassingly hard. Looking up profiles, seeing what my own profile name is so I can tell people how to friend me is so confusing.

★★★★★ January 8, 2023

I pretty much use the app to make a book I'm currently reading and look up a review when I'm in the library or a book store. The rest (writing reviews, etc) I just do on the website. That's because the app is buggy and clunky. I've found books marked as Read instead of Currently reading. And recently Reviews don't show up at all under the books I look up. The most convenient thing is the scanner to look up a book to add to my list. That's it. The last update caused the bugs.

★★★★★ December 8, 2022

The app is mostly a wrapper for a website. It does its job okay. I can keep track of books and look at reviews. But it doesn't have a dark mode, has very few settings, a lot of the pages are pretty basic, and the fact that a lot of the app is just a website has its own annoying problems.

Figure 20 App store & Google Play reviews, 2023

Goodreads has a 4.8 star rating with 1.9K ratings in the App Store and a 3.6 star rating with 136K reviews in Google Play. In general, most of the reviews can be summarized in one thought: the app, idea, and concept are amazing, but the execution is terrible, and users feel their feedback is not being heard.

4.1.2. Articles and other reviews

- *“UI doesn’t seem updated since 2007, is unimaginative, and clunky” (35)*
- *“My main issues with the design of it is that a lot of text is way too small, there’s not enough space in between certain areas, and there’s not enough weight or color different in the font(s).” (35)*
- *“The recommendations suck, the lists suck — it’s like 100 lists telling me to read ‘The Handmaid’s Tale’ and ‘Harry Potter.’” (34)*

Based on user feedback and industry best practices, there are several areas where the Goodreads app could potentially improve:

1. **UI & UX Design overall:** Some users have reported that the app's UI is cluttered and difficult to navigate, especially for new users. Modernising the UI and simplifying the app's navigation could help make it more user-friendly.
2. **Search functionality:** Users have reported difficulty finding books or authors they're interested in. Improving the app's search functionality, including refining search filters and adding more intuitive search suggestions, could help users find the books they're looking for more easily.
3. **Social Features:** Goodreads is known for its social features, such as the ability to connect with other readers, join book clubs, and share book recommendations. However, some users have suggested that the app could do more to encourage and facilitate these social interactions, like personalising profile or simplifying the way to add new friend or follow someone.
4. **Personalization:** Goodreads provides personalized book recommendations based on users' reading history, but some users have reported that these recommendations aren't always accurate or relevant.

In the practical part of my thesis, I will focus on improving user experience in accordance with modern practices and user preferences. Since redesigning an entire app is a lot of work, I will focus on three specific scenarios that a users might encounter while using Goodreads and suggest improvements to their experience.

4.2. Selecting specific personas and scenarios

Creating user scenarios is a common method that is being used in UX design, because they can help designers understand the needs and expectations of their users and meet them. They are stories that describe how a user might interact with a product or service in a particular situation (14).

A person can use goodreads for a huge number of things - add a book to the shelf, leave a review, rate a book, share with friends, find new friends, complete a challenge for the year, find new books for themselves and much more. For this thesis, I have chosen three specific scenarios to try to improve user experience of:

1. One type of reader simply wants to keep track of the number of books they read. This reader may make use of the Shelves section and Book detail section of the application. He might want to create a list of books to take on vacation, or mark a book as finished or DNF another one.
2. Another reader has a collection of physical books and enjoys lists and organization. She might be very particular about book releases and cover picks when buying offline. On the app, she is not very active in the community, but always saves book selections and may want to change the book edition or its cover.

3. The third person is quite active on social media and likes to watch booktubers' videos to find recommendations on new books and authors. She wants to follow her favorite bloggers to see what they are currently reading.

I selected these specific scenarios because they received the most negative feedback from users. I aimed to use a "minimum effective dose" of UX improvements that wouldn't require a significant investment for the company to implement, but would enhance satisfaction and comfort when using the app. I have considered other scenarios, for instance a reading challenge, but I have concluded that the reading challenge works and is "good enough". While there is always room for improvement, the 20/80 rule suggests that focusing on 20% of the necessary edits will yield 80% of the desired results (50), so I decided to focus on what made sense the most.

4. Redesigning Goodreads

Moving on to the practical part of the work, I will follow these steps:

1. After analyzing the theoretical part of the work, I will prepare for the practical part. This involves preparing the file in Figma, creating wireframes, selecting a grid etc.
2. I will create screenshots of each scenario in Figma, organizing them in a logical order. This will help me refine the design and choose specific elements to focus on.
3. I will prepare the components, colors, and fonts I plan to use in order to speed up the process. I will use some from freely available files in the Figma Community, and refine the rest myself without delving into UI design and visual solutions.
4. Next, I will design the screens needed for each scenario, building on the existing design from the elements mentioned in step 3.
5. At this point, I will start making my proposed UX changes based on user feedback and basic UX principles.
6. During this time, I will analyze and compare the resulting design with the current Goodreads app.
7. After that, I will create an interactive prototype of each scenario in Figma.
8. Finally, I will test these scenarios and gather new feedback.

To begin analyzing and improving an application's user experience, it's important to thoroughly examine the existing flow. I started by taking screenshots of each screen and arranging them in order in Figma, simulating scenarios for selected personas. This allowed me to better understand how users interact with the app and highlight specific elements on each screen.

From there, I was able to design the wireframes and flow for each scenario.

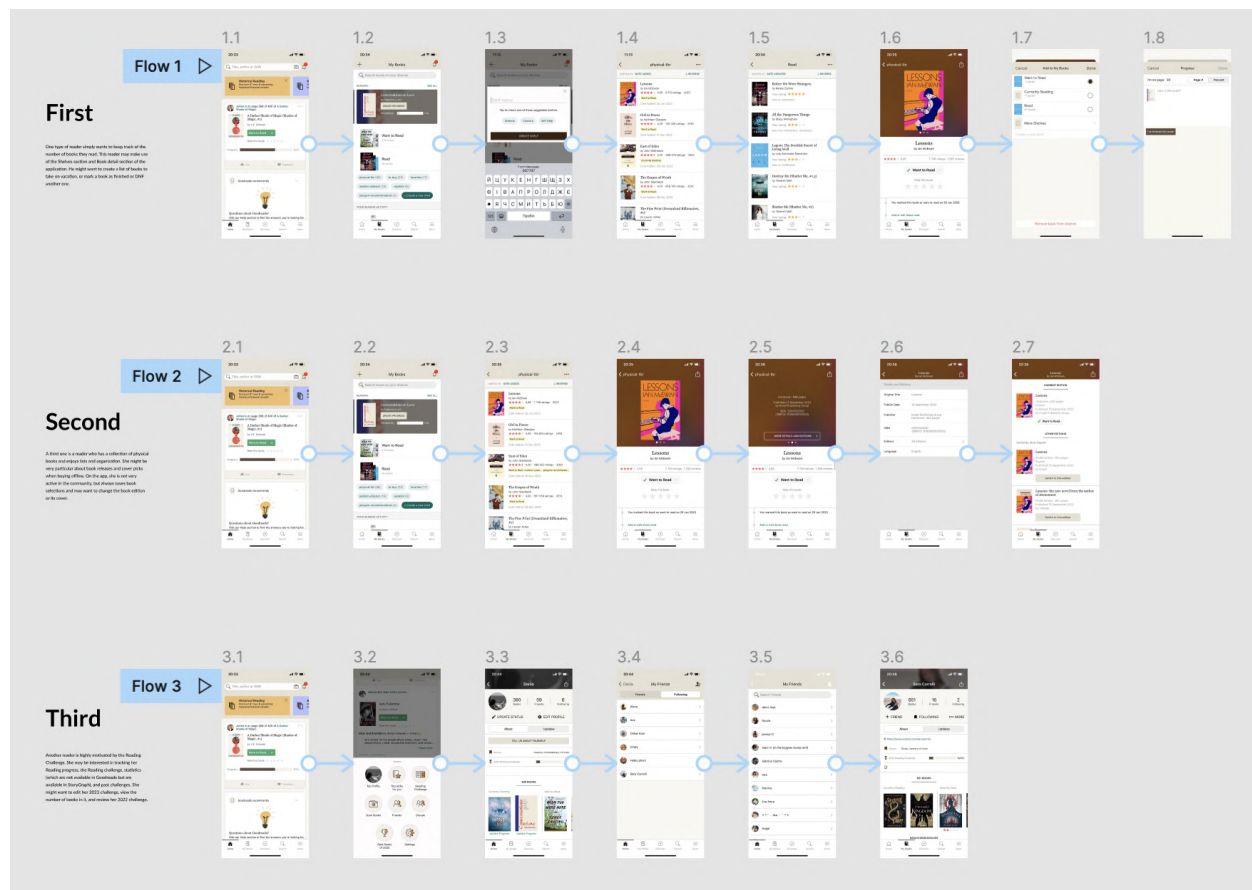


Figure 21 User flows in Figma, 2023

5.1. Wireframing

Before creating a wireframe, it is important to plan out the structure and content of design. I started with identifying the key pages and features, as well as the hierarchy and flow of information. I have thought through what features I want to add and where. At this stage, all that was needed was experience and user feedback, careful consideration of the scenarios, and a pen and paper.

5.2. Preparation for designing in Figma

Figma is simple to use - it is enough to create a new file and the frames in it with which I plan to work. Figma also allows to select the correct screen resolution according to the device. The basic structure is created with the classic objects like rectangles, circles, images, icons and text.

One of the biggest advantages for me is the Figma community. While searching on “Goodreads”, I came across several public domain files, including "[Replicating Amazon Goodreads App](#)" by [Uno Platform](#). Although they offer a somewhat outdated design system, it's still useful for quickly creating wireframes.

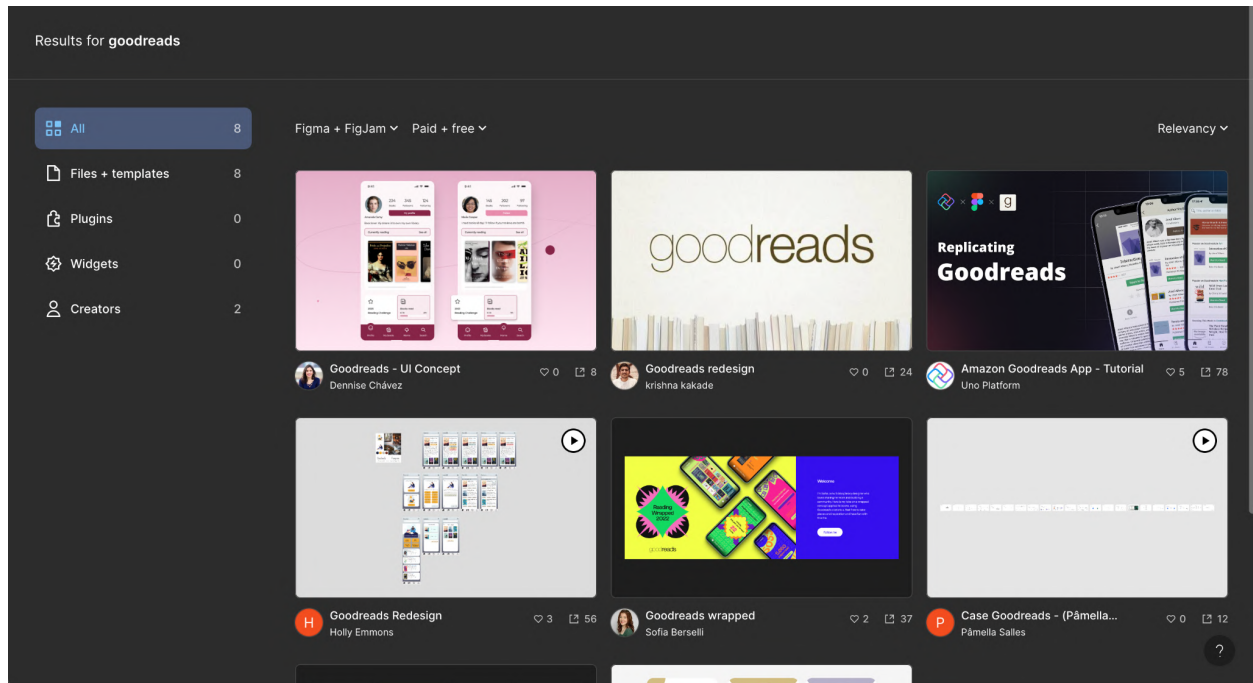


Figure 22 Search results for the word "Goodreads" in the Figma community, 2023

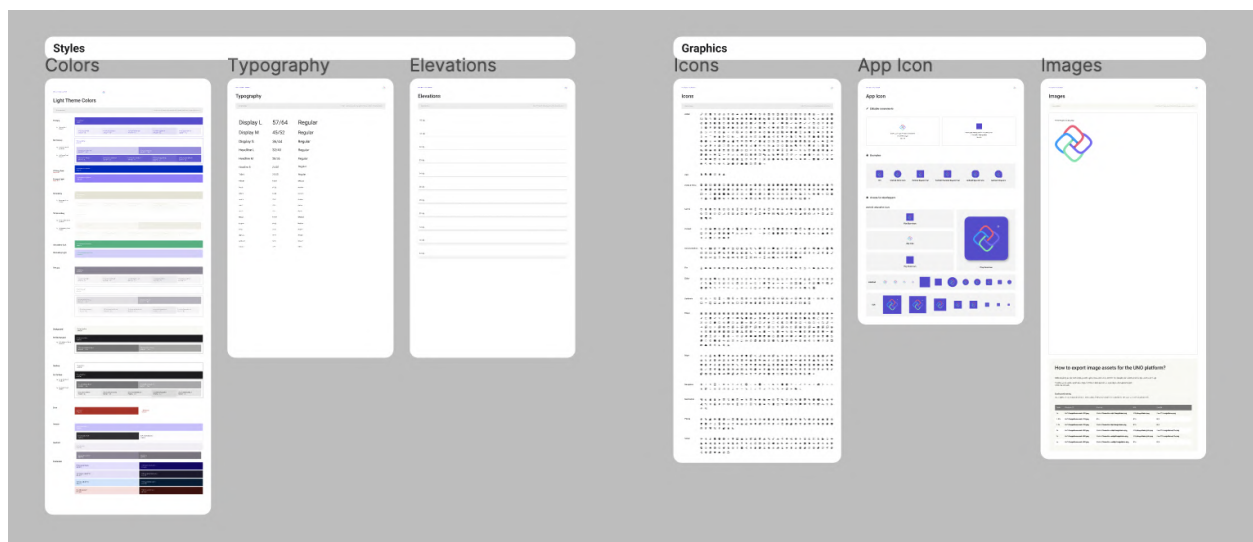


Figure 23 "[Replicating Amazon Goodreads App](#)" Design System by [Uno Platform](#), 2023

I created a "UI Kit" page in Figma and began preparing for the work by creating text and color styles. Uno Platform offered Roboto font, but i checked what font Goodreads uses with the [WhatFont plugin](#) and found out that it was Lato, so I changed the font in the Design system.

Going into detail about fonts, sizes, and so on is not the purpose of my work, but I have refined them a bit for my own convenience. So after some minor changes, the fonts looked like this:

Display L	57/64	Regular	Heading 1	28/36	Regular
Display M	45/52	Regular	Heading 2	24/32	Regular
Display S	36/44	Regular	Heading 3	22/28	Regular
Headline L	32/40	Regular	Heading 4	16/24	Medium
Headline M	28/36	Regular	Heading 5	14/20	Medium
Headline S	24/32	Regular	Label 1	14/20	Medium
Title L	22/28	Regular	Label M	12/16	Medium
Title M	16/24	Medium	Label S	11/16	Medium
Title S	14/20	Medium	Label XS	11/16	Regular
Label L	14/20	Medium	Body 1	16/24	Medium
Label M	12/16	Medium	Body M	14/20	Medium
Label S	11/16	Medium	Body S	12/16	Medium
Label XS	11/16	Regular	Caption 1	13/18	Medium
Body L	16/24	Medium	Caption 2	12/16	Medium
Body M	14/20	Medium	Caption 3	11/13	Medium
Body S	12/16	Medium			
Caption L	13/18	Medium			
Caption M	12/16	Medium			
Caption S	11/13	Medium			

Figure 24 Uno Platform Text styles vs. Project text styles, 2023

Text styles ▼ Typography Ag H1 · 28/36 Ag H2 · 24/32 Ag H3 · 22/28 Ag H4 · 16/24 Ag H5 · 14/20 ▼ Labels Ag L1 · 14/20 Ag L2 · 12/16 Ag L3 · 11/16 Ag L4 · 11/16	▼ Body Ag P1 · 16/24 Ag P2 · 14/20 Ag P3 · 12/16 ▼ Captions Ag C1 · 13/18 Ag C2 · 12/16 Ag C3 · 11/13
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Figure 25 Text Styles, 2023

Uno Platform also offers a purple color, but Goodreads does not utilize it. However, as it is not the focus of my thesis, I will not go into this further.

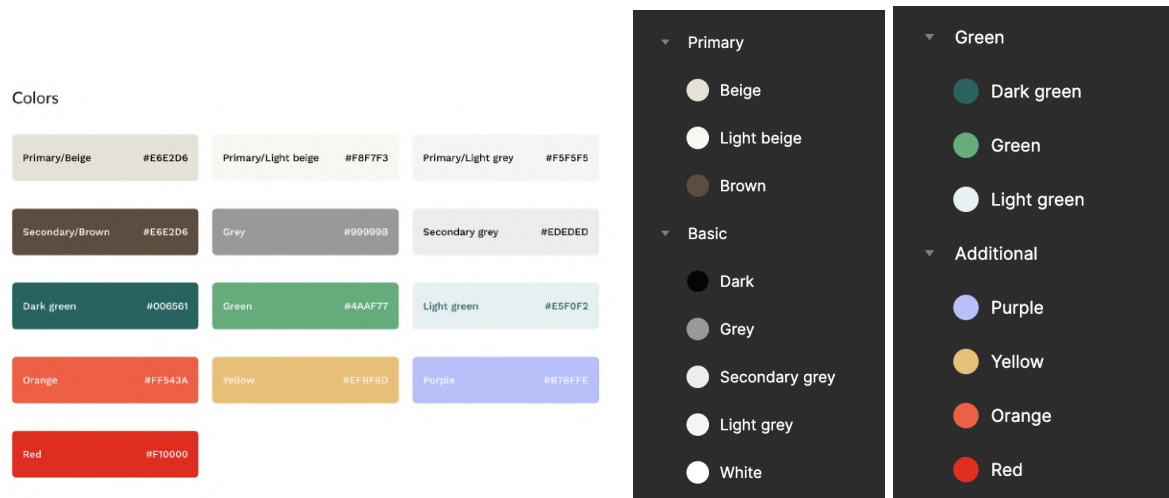


Figure 26 Color Styles

I selected colors for the wireframes using a color picker and Goodreads screenshots. While there may be many more colors in the UI kit, including success, danger, attention, and other states, I only needed the primary colors for the wireframes.

5.2.1. Grids

Starting the redesign, I also picked the right column grid. A grid is a series of vertical (and sometimes horizontal) lines that serve as a framework for organizing content on a page. They can be used to help with layout and alignment of design elements (36).

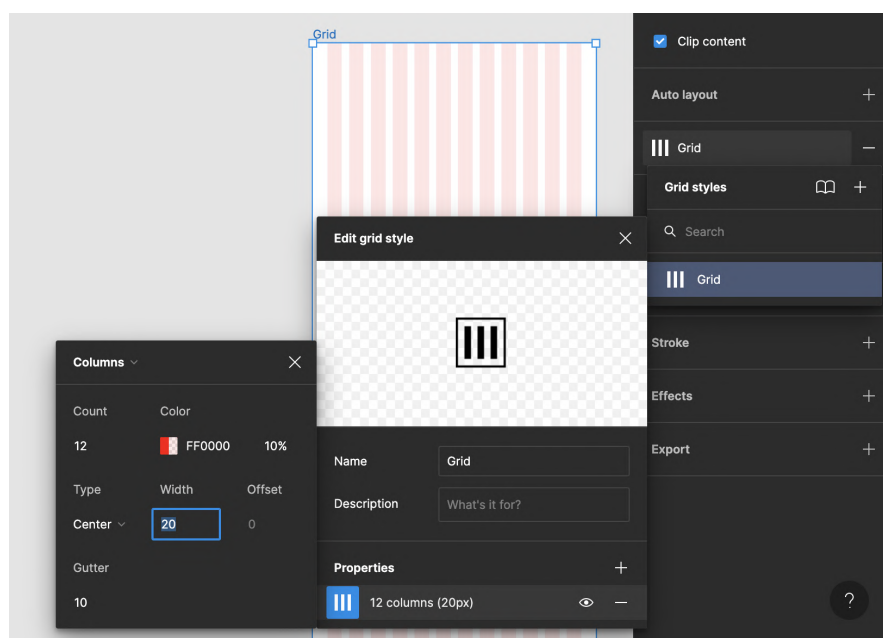


Figure 27 Grids, 2023

Afterward, I began copying the structure of the first flow screens. I did not want to use a black-and-white wireframes, as I wanted my design to be more visually appealing. This is why my wireframes resemble a real app while still being quick to create in terms of design and time.

5.2.2. Figma components

I used components, which are also known as symbols, to speed up my work and make it more convenient to change a larger number of elements at once. Components in Figma are reusable design elements that can be thought of as building blocks that can be combined to create more complex designs.

When i created a component, i was creating a master version of that design element. Any changes i will make to the component will be reflected in all instances of that component throughout design. This makes it easy to make changes to design without having to update each individual instance of a design element.

To create elements such as stream cards on the home page, I have used properties. For instance, I have implemented the "Popular on Goodreads" card and the user review card.

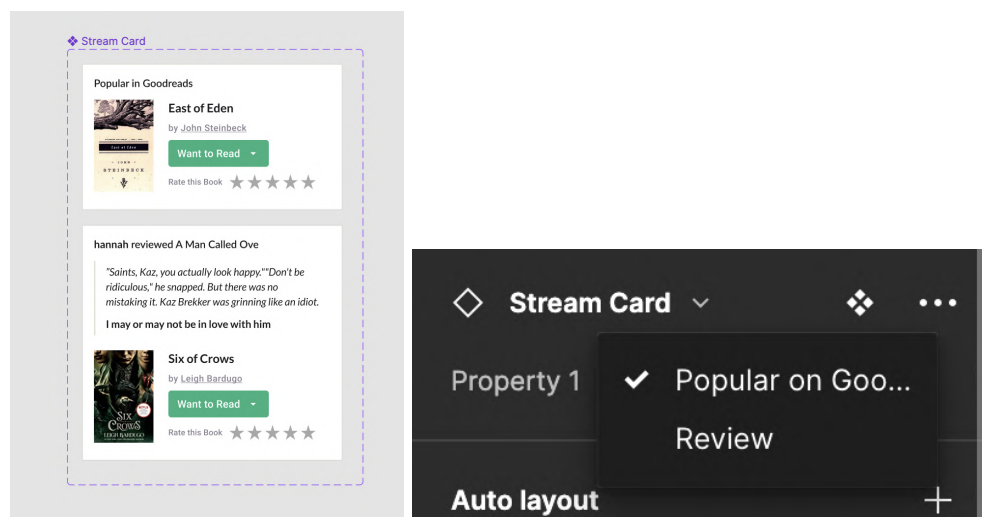


Figure 28 Components, 2023

5.2.3. Auto-layouts

Starting from the home page, I used Figma's "auto-layouts" feature to quickly create a consistent layout for my design, which allowed me to quickly create a consistent layout for my design. With auto-layouts, I can easily adjust the spacing and alignment of elements within the design, ensuring that everything looks clean and organized. It also saves time by automatically resizing elements as needed, reducing the amount of manual adjustment required (37).

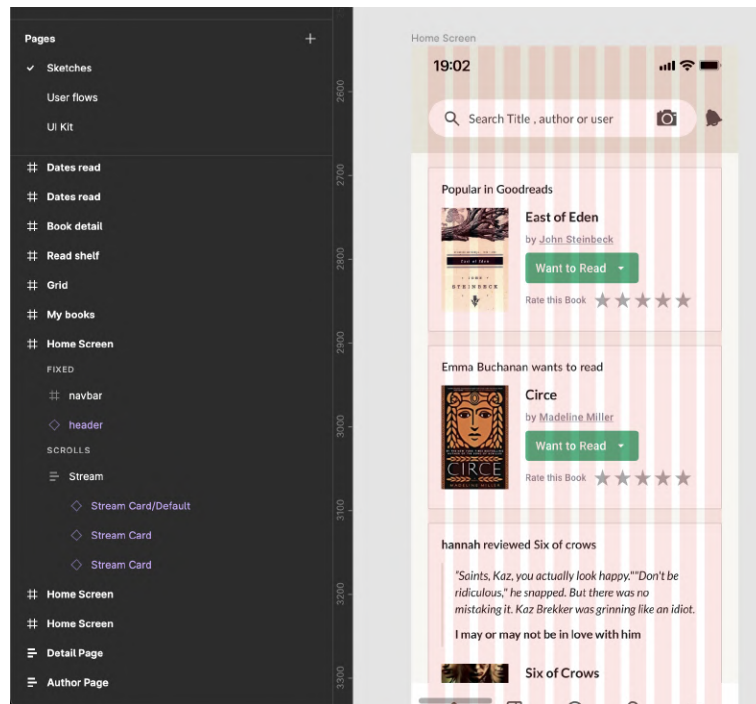


Figure 29 Auto-layouts, 2023

5.3. UX redesign

5.3.1. First scenario

With everything prepared and ready to go, I started the redesign process with the first scenario user flow for regular readers who simply want to keep track of the books they have read. These readers can make use of the Shelves section and Book detail section of the application. They may want to create a list of books, mark a book as finished or DNF it.

The user's touch points in the app were:

- Home page
- "My books" section
- Creating a new bookshelf and adding books to it
- Updating book progress
- Book detail
- Reading dates

- Giving a book a rating

Now, i will examine the main problems this user may have encountered.

5.3.1.1. Creating a new shelf and adding books to it

When you create a new shelf, you can't add books to it right away. The user path looks like this:

1. Create Shelf.
2. Name the shelf.
3. App will redirect you to the shelf page.
4. Click "Add Books".
5. App takes you to book search section.
6. Find a book or go to a book category.
7. Go to the book page.
8. Click on the "Read" status of the book.
9. Click on "More shelves".
10. Select a shelf.
11. Click "Done".
12. Go to the shelves page.
13. Choose the shelf you want..
14. Done, see that the book is on the shelf.

The process of creating a new shelf and adding a book to it consists of 14 steps, not even including the homepage, which is unnecessarily complicated. In an effort to simplify the process, I have condensed it to just four screens.

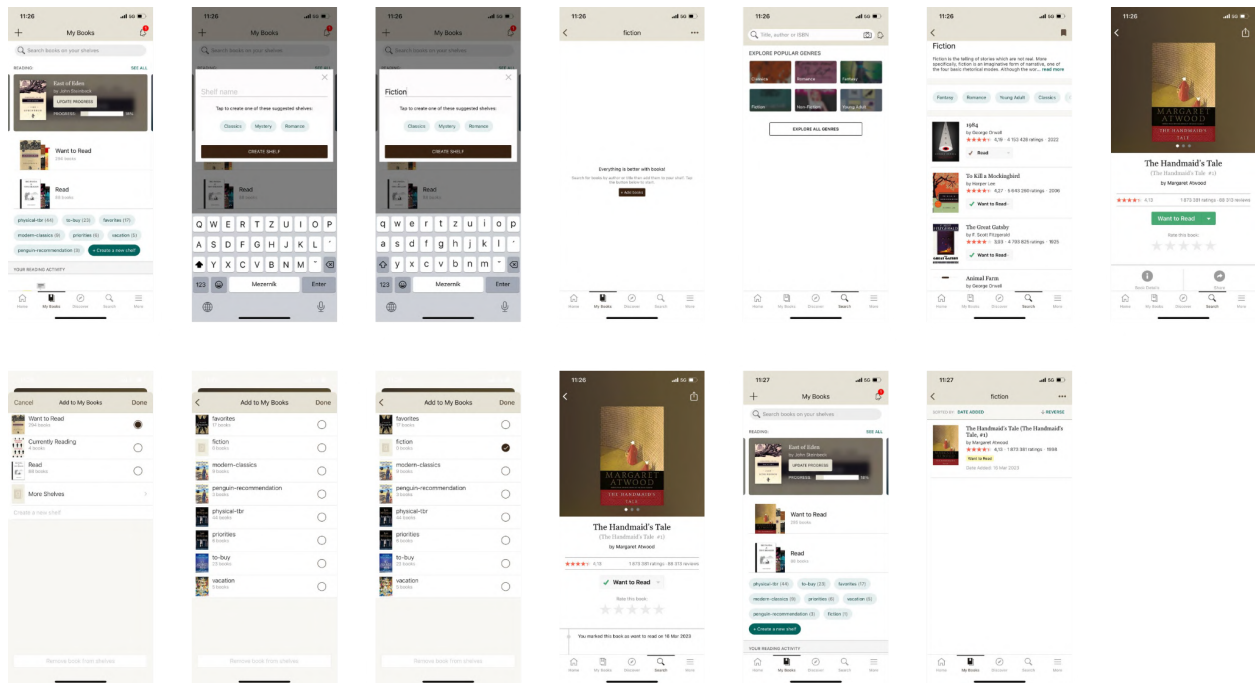


Figure 30 The user path of creating a new shelf in Goodreads, 2023

In my new flow user:

1. On the "my books" page, clicks on "create a shelf."
2. Writes a shelf name or automatically chooses one of the suggested ones.
3. The app redirects him to the shelf page, where he can tap on any number of suggested books and they will automatically be added to the shelf, or he can search above for a book and also add it by tap to the book card. In the circle on the book cover the book will be marked green as "added". You can immediately save the shelf with the added books or skip adding them.
4. The app leaves the user on that shelf page, where they can see books either by adding new ones with the "plus" button at the top, or by searching for books on the shelf in the search at the top.

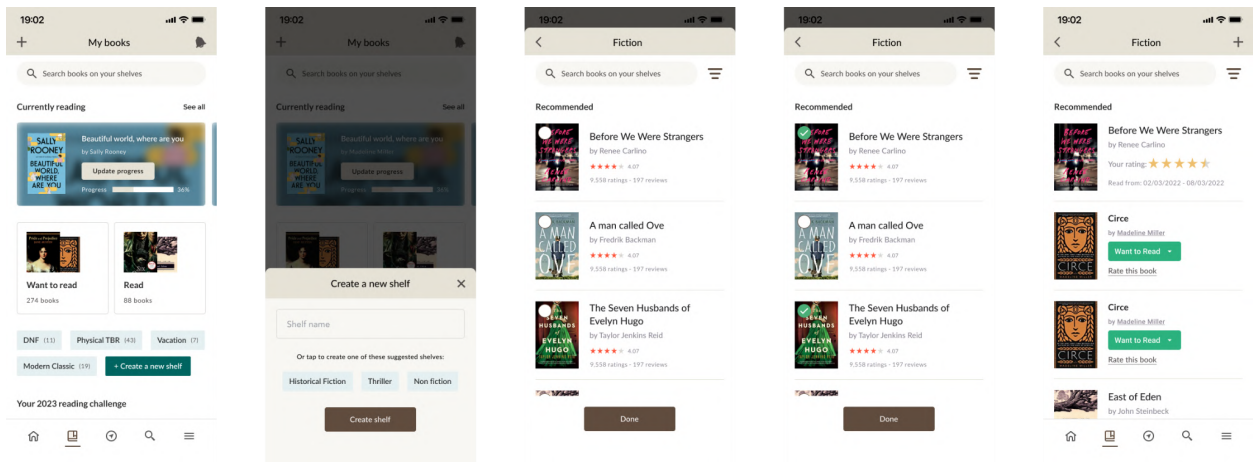


Figure 31 The new user path of creating a new shelf, 2023

5.3.1.2. Users cannot mark a book as "DNF"

Sometimes readers struggle with not finishing books, which in the book world is called "DNF" (did not finish). The Goodreads Help section offers users the option to create a DNF shelf themselves (38). However, this is not user-friendly when they could add that feature.

To improve user experience, I have added some DNF touchpoints to the app, including:

1. A premade DNF shelf in the "My Books" section, which is available to all users.
2. When updating the progress of reading a book, users have the option (primary call-to-action) to finish the book or mark it as "Did not finish."
3. When the user adds a book to My Books, he can add it to the DNF shelf.

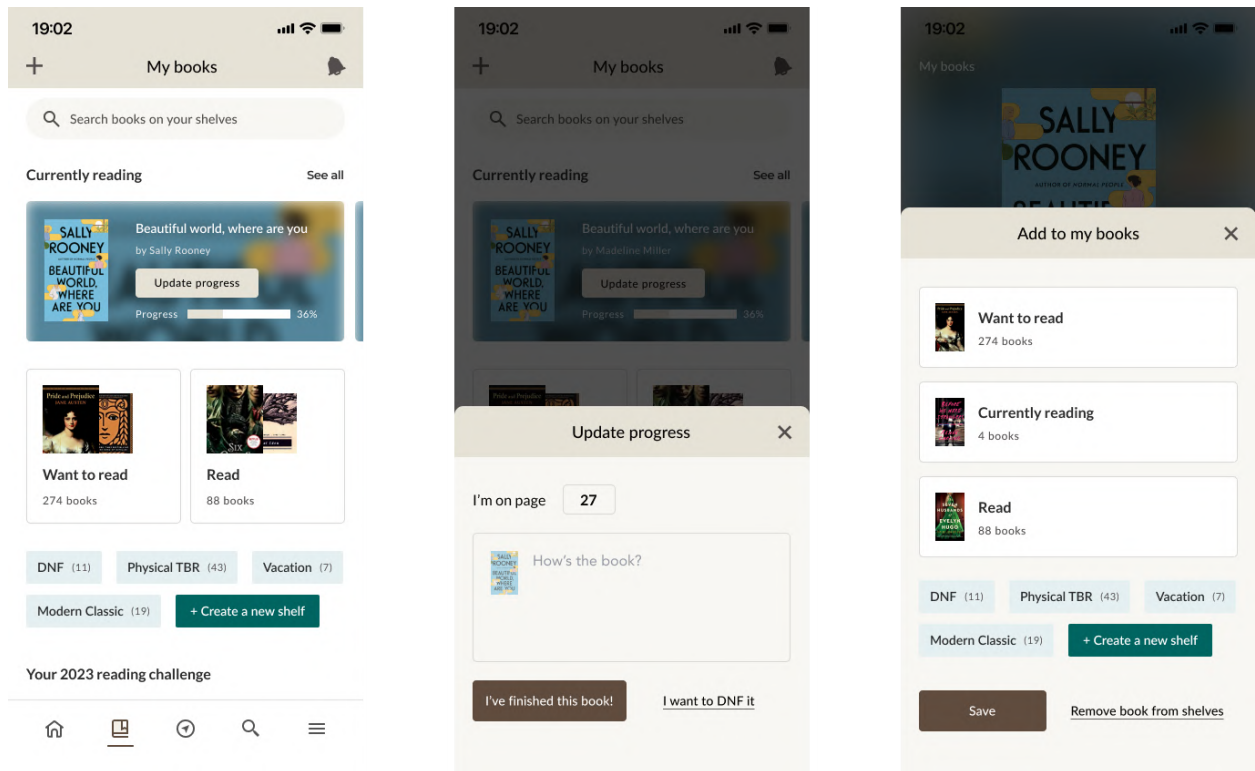


Figure 32 Marking a book as DNF, 2023

5.3.1.3. Unable to save reading dates

When adding dates of reading a book, there is no "save" button. I have to close the module and Goodreads saves these dates automatically, but the user may not know about it. Even after 1.5 years of using the app, I am still scared to close this module every time as I don't want to enter dates again.

I added a primary "Save" button and a secondary "Add new dates" button. In the current app, there is only an "Add dates" button, which can confuse the user as it serves to add re-reading dates (a second, third time, for example). This change will help users to save their reading dates with confidence and avoid the fear of losing their entered data.

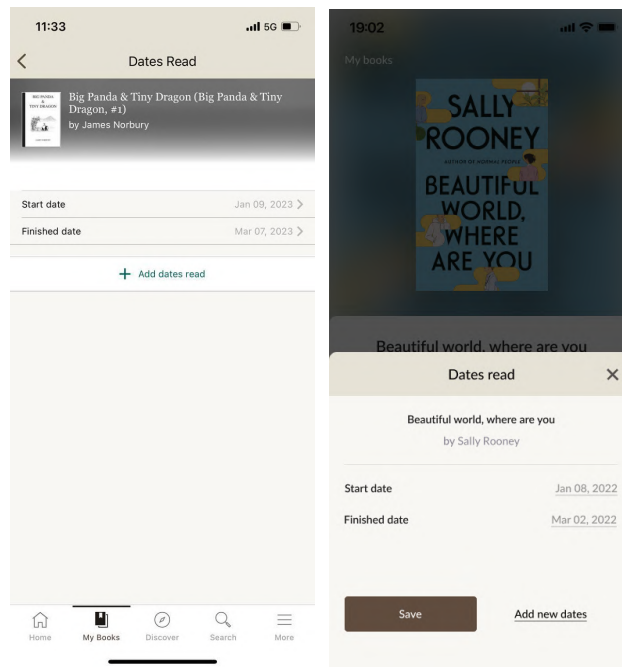


Figure 33 Dates read on Goodreads, 2023

In the end, the flow of the first scenario looked like this:

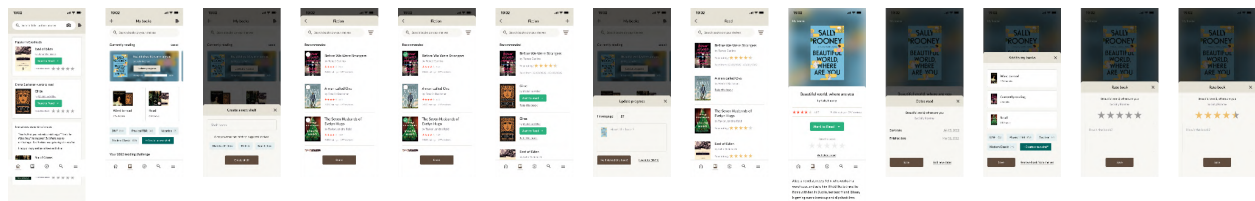


Figure 34 User flow of saving reading dates, 2023

5.3.1.4. Book quotes are not in the book detail

I added a section with quotes from the book to the horizontal tab scroll on the book page. By adding those tabs, I also reduced the amount of scrolling required by the user. Previously, users had to scroll through several other categories to get to the recommendations based on this book, but now they can access everything through the tab navigation.

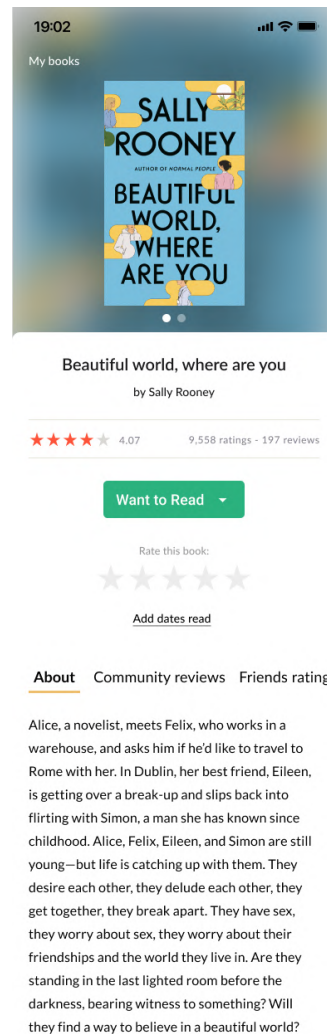


Figure 35 Book quotes, 2023

5.3.1.5. Half star rating

I added the ability to rate a book with half a star, as it was one of the most common complaints about Goodreads.

5.3.1.6. Conclusion

In this section i tried to make improvements to the Goodreads app's user flow for regular readers who want to keep track of the books they have read. Three main problems included the complicated process of creating a new shelf and adding books to it, the inability to mark a book as "DNF," and the lack of a "save" button when adding reading dates. I proposed solutions to

these problems, including condensing the process of creating a new shelf, adding a premade DNF shelf, and adding a "save" button for reading dates.

5.3.2. Second scenario

The second scenario was less complicated because the user's main goal is to change the book edition. As mentioned in section 4.1, this reader has a collection of physical books and appreciates lists and organization. She may be particular about book releases and cover picks when buying offline. On the app, she is not very active in the community but frequently saves book selections and may want to change the book edition or cover.

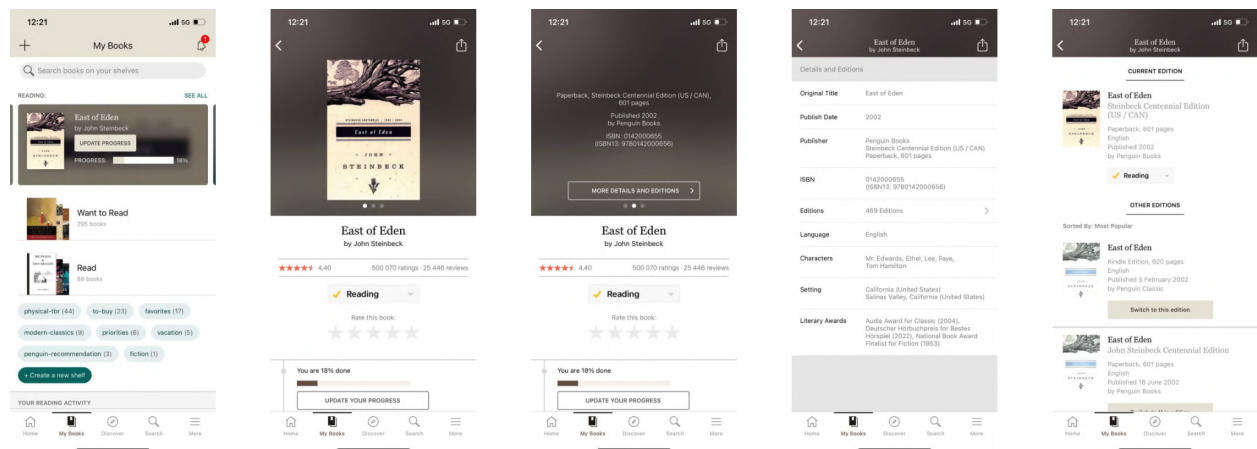


Figure 36 Second scenario, 2023

5.3.2.1. Changing book edition

This image shows the flow a user goes through when they want to change book editions within the Goodreads app. In the recently redesigned web desktop version of Goodreads, they have made updates to make accessing book editions faster and easier:

5.1.4. Third scenario

Improvements:

- The "Friend" and "Following" buttons on the user's profile unclear and would benefit from having a clearer indication of what these buttons do.
- *It would be great to have my current reading or favorite books displayed on my profile page, possibly above the genres and 2023 challenge information.*

5.1.5. Incorporation of feedback

I decided to make several improvements, which I later confirmed with subsequent testers, and they confirmed that they made sense.

5.1.5.1. *How's the book?* box

A user pointed out that it may be unclear whether this progress will be published or not, so I provided an explanation right in the input field.

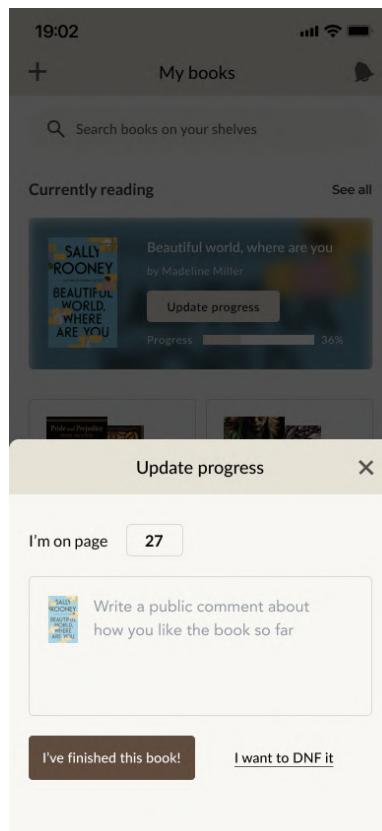


Figure 44 Update progress screen, 2023

5.1.5.2. Currently reading book progress

Based on the feedback from one of the testers, i decided to app displaying the percentage of progress on the book when it is marked as "Currently Reading". It will be helpful for users to see that they will not avoid losing progress when switching editions.

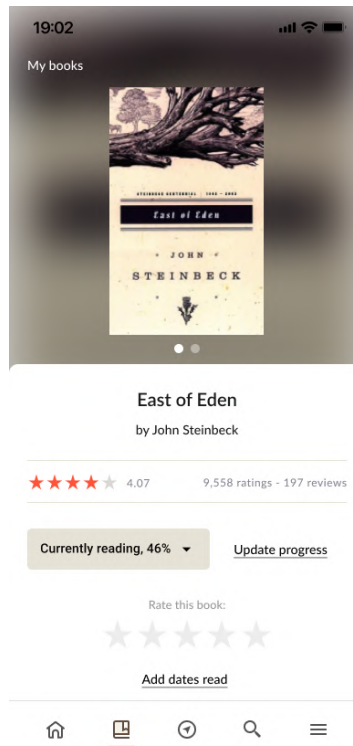


Figure 45 Book detail screen, 2023

5.1.5.3. Users' favorites

The user detail screen already includes favorite books and genres.

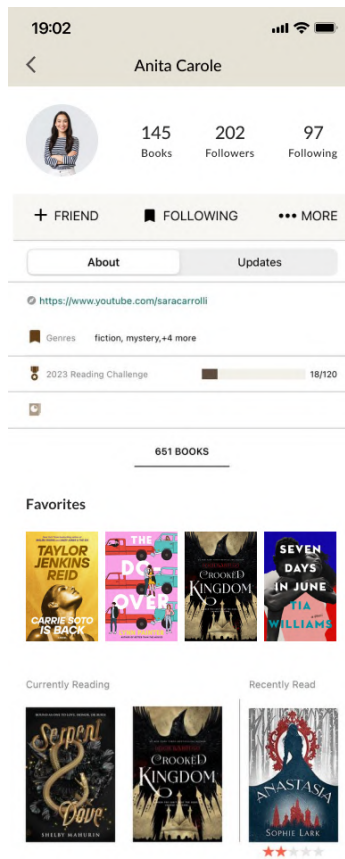


Figure 46 User detail screen, 2023

5.1.6. Conclusion

As I mentioned before, conducting testing was not the goal of this thesis from the start (which is why I did not do quantitative testing). Design processes are iterative and endless, and it's crucial to know how much time and money a company is willing to invest in a specific redesign and when to stop, so i wanted to tests the main ideas. With the help of this testing, I was able to ensure that my redesign is on the right track.

Conclusion

For my bachelor's thesis, I conducted a UX redesign of the popular Goodreads application (version 2022) for specific user scenarios. I chose three different scenarios, which represent different types of users and their specific needs and expectations from Goodreads. The first scenario represents a user who is interested in tracking their reading progress, while the second represents a user who is interested in organizing their physical book collection. The third scenario represents a user who is interested in discovering new books and authors through social media. The aim of this work was to improve the user experience of the application and make it more intuitive for users to navigate through the app.

In the theoretical part, I explored the concepts of UX and UI design, the differences between them and a concept of design process. I also discussed the various applications that designers use in their work. Furthermore, I reviewed the history of the Goodreads, its direct and indirect competition.

In the practical part of my thesis, I followed a series of steps to design and refine the user experience of the Goodreads app. I started by analyzing the theoretical part of the work and then prepared for the practical part by creating wireframes, selecting a grid, and preparing the components, colors, and fonts to be used. I then designed screens for each scenario and made proposed UX changes based on user feedback and basic UX principles. I analyzed and compared the resulting design with the current Goodreads app, created an interactive prototype of the new design to demonstrate how it would work in practice. In addition to redesign, this bachelor's thesis also includes user experience testing. A total of six users participated in the testing process, providing feedback on the proposed UX changes and suggesting additional improvements.

The output of the work includes three user flows in Figma, along with an interactive prototype. These prototypes serve as a visual representation of the new design, which can be used to gather feedback from potential users.

Overall, the bachelor's thesis aimed to provide an in-depth analysis of the Goodreads application and develop a UX redesign that would improve the overall user experience.

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Appendices

Appendix A: Link to Figma with UI Kit, user flows, and interactive prototype.

<https://www.figma.com/file/yQFfe5Q4Lxh8VSxtOGS9iH/goodreads?type=design&node-id=57%3A47637&t=cu10QTYdd09Qsxdx-1>

Appendix B: Link to interactive prototype in Figma (1 scenario).

<https://www.figma.com/proto/yQFfe5Q4Lxh8VSxtOGS9iH/goodreads?page-id=57%3A47637&type=design&node-id=57-47639&viewport=390%2C243%2Co.07&scaling=min-zoom&starting-point-node-id=57%3A47639&show-proto-sidebar=1>

Appendix C: Link to interactive prototype in Figma (2 scenario).

<https://www.figma.com/proto/yQFfe5Q4Lxh8VSxtOGS9iH/goodreads?page-id=57%3A47637&type=design&node-id=57-49522&viewport=390%2C243%2Co.07&scaling=min-zoom&starting-point-node-id=57%3A49522&show-proto-sidebar=1>

Appendix D: Link to interactive prototype in Figma (3 scenario).

<https://www.figma.com/proto/yQFfe5Q4Lxh8VSxtOGS9iH/goodreads?page-id=57%3A47637&type=design&node-id=57-50317&viewport=390%2C243%2Co.07&scaling=min-zoom&starting-point-node-id=57%3A50317&show-proto-sidebar=1>

List of images

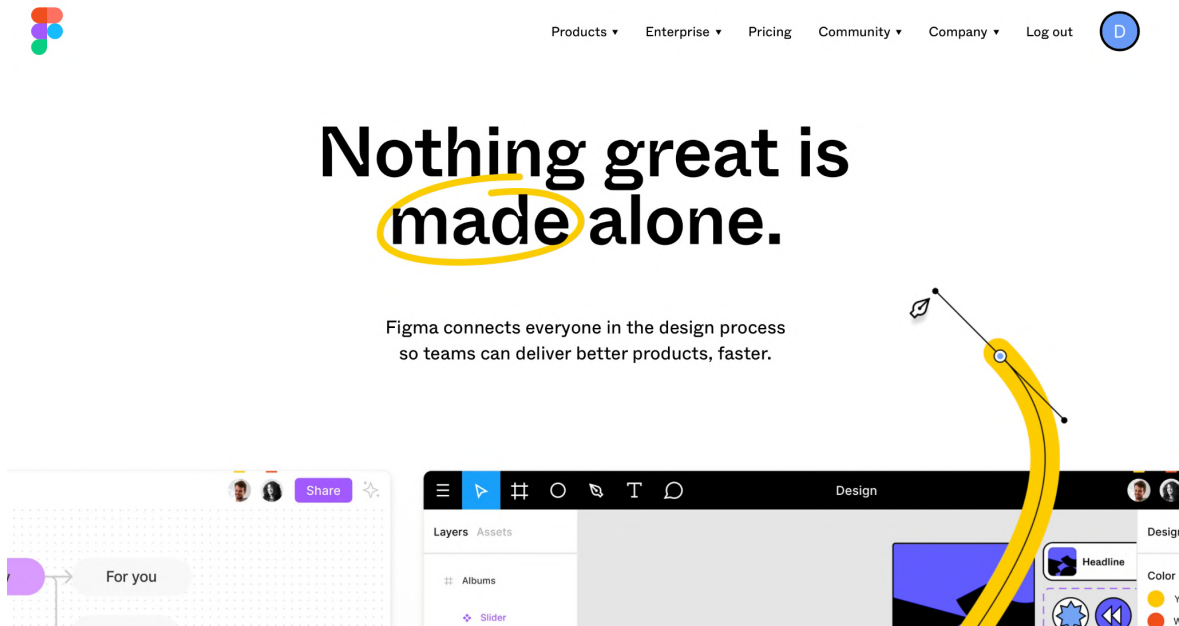


Figure 1 Figma, 2023 (© 2023 Figma.com)

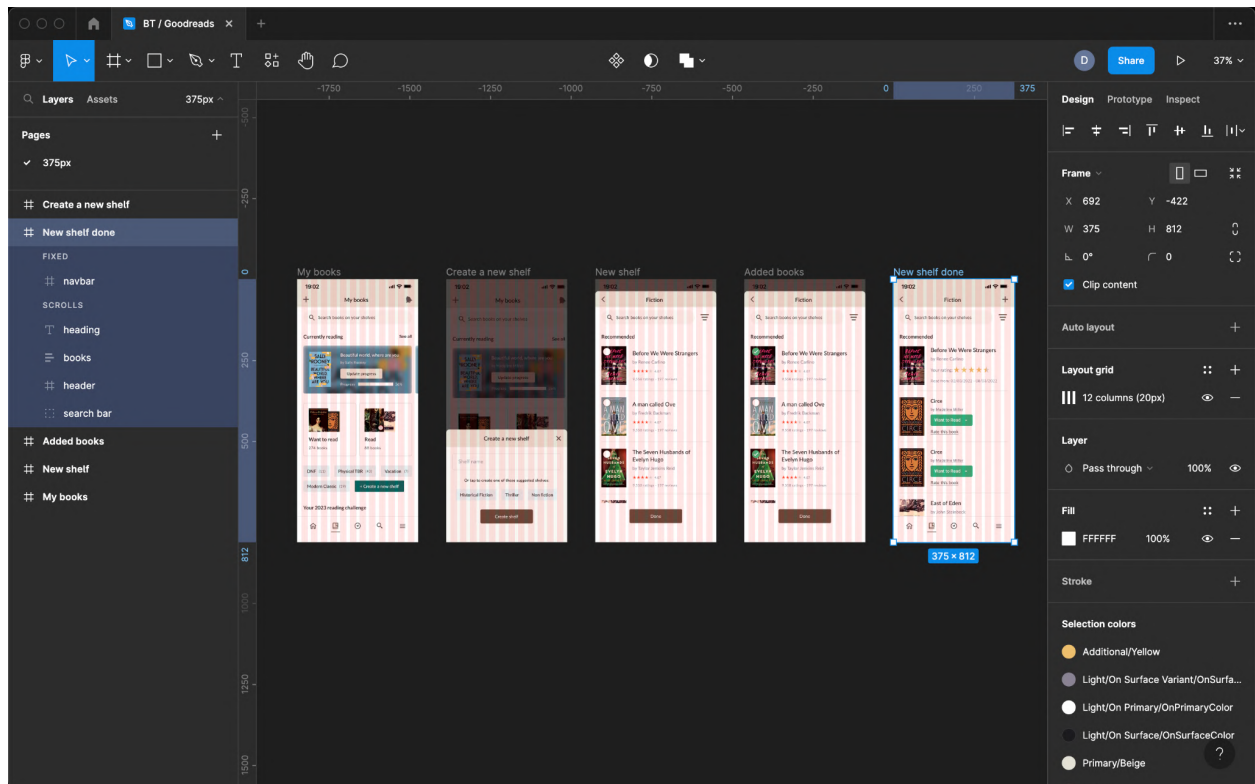


Figure 2 Figma Interface, 2023

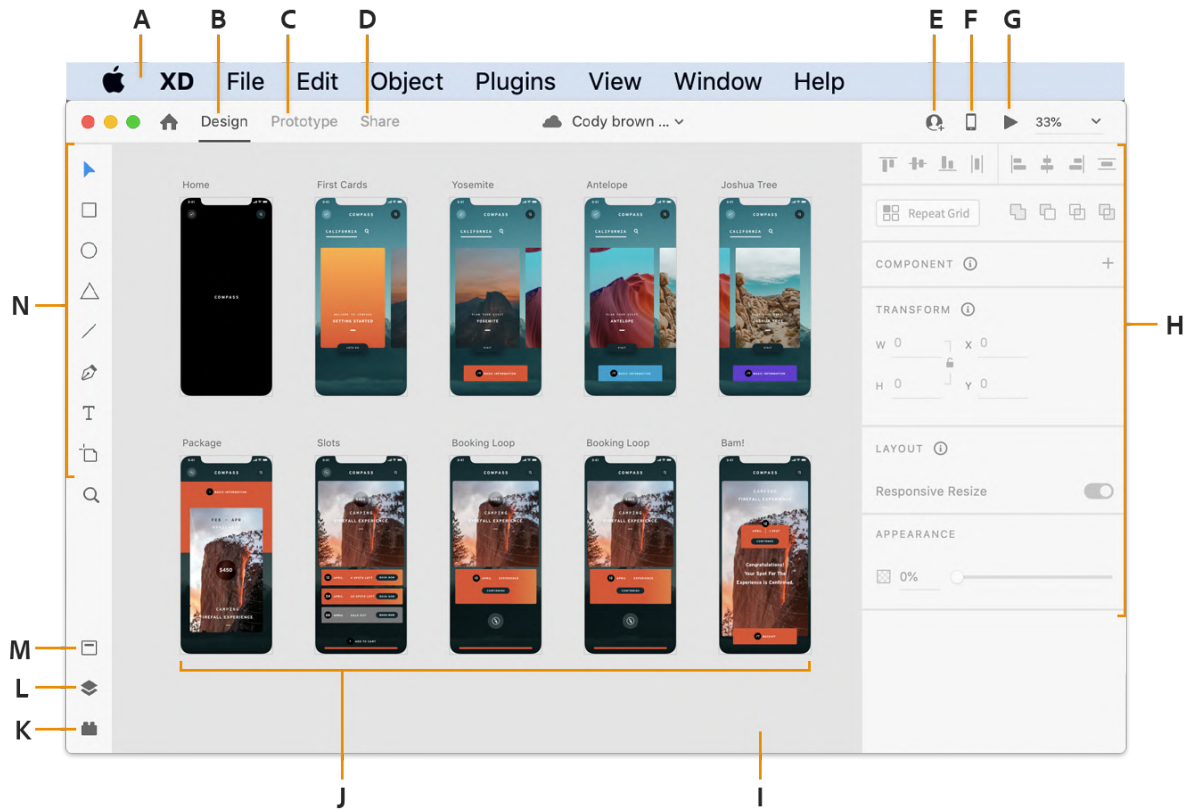


Figure 3 Adobe XD, 2023 (© 2023 Adobe.com)

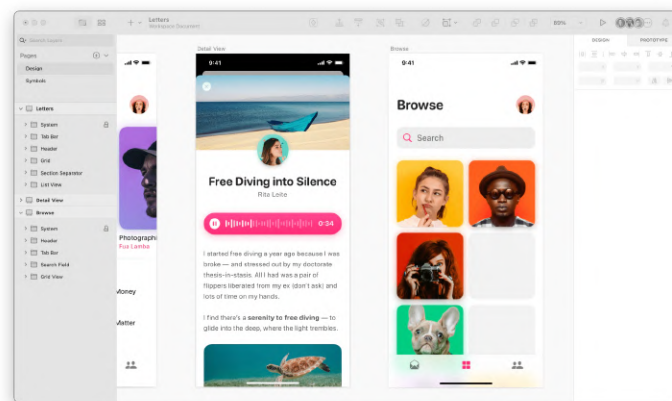


Figure 4 Sketch (© 2023 Sketch B.V.)

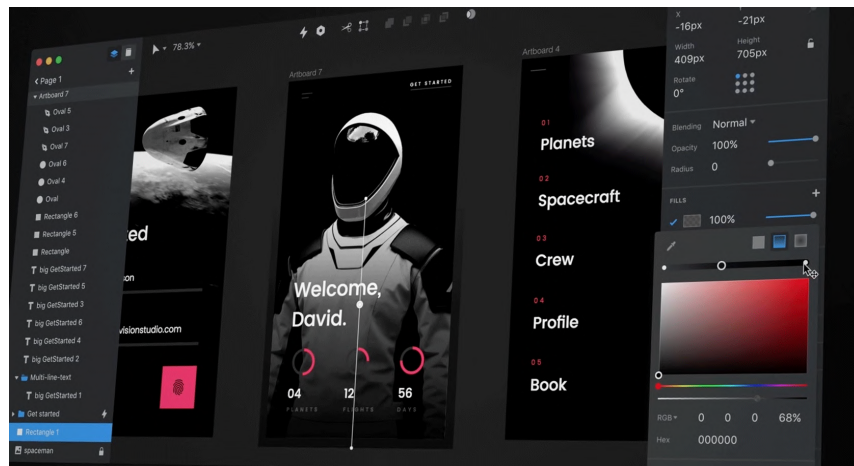


Figure 5 InVision (Toptal, LLC © 2010-2023)

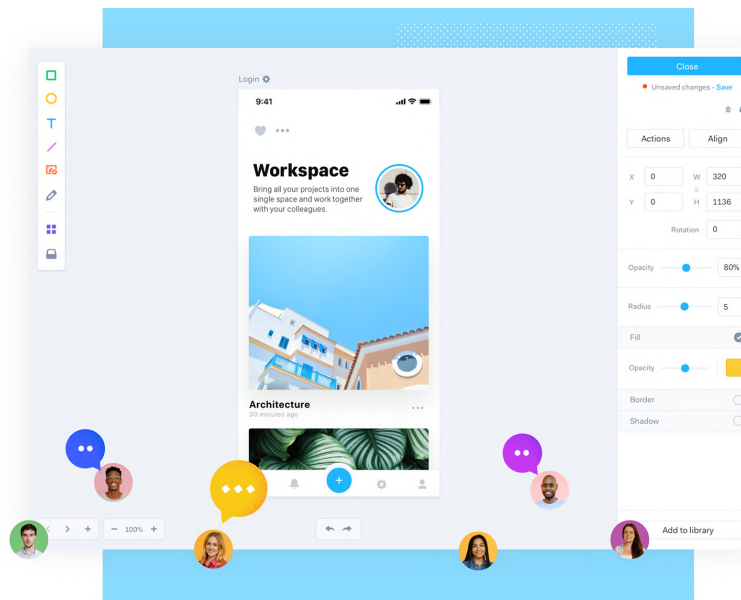


Figure 6 Marvel (Marvel Prototyping Ltd., 2023)

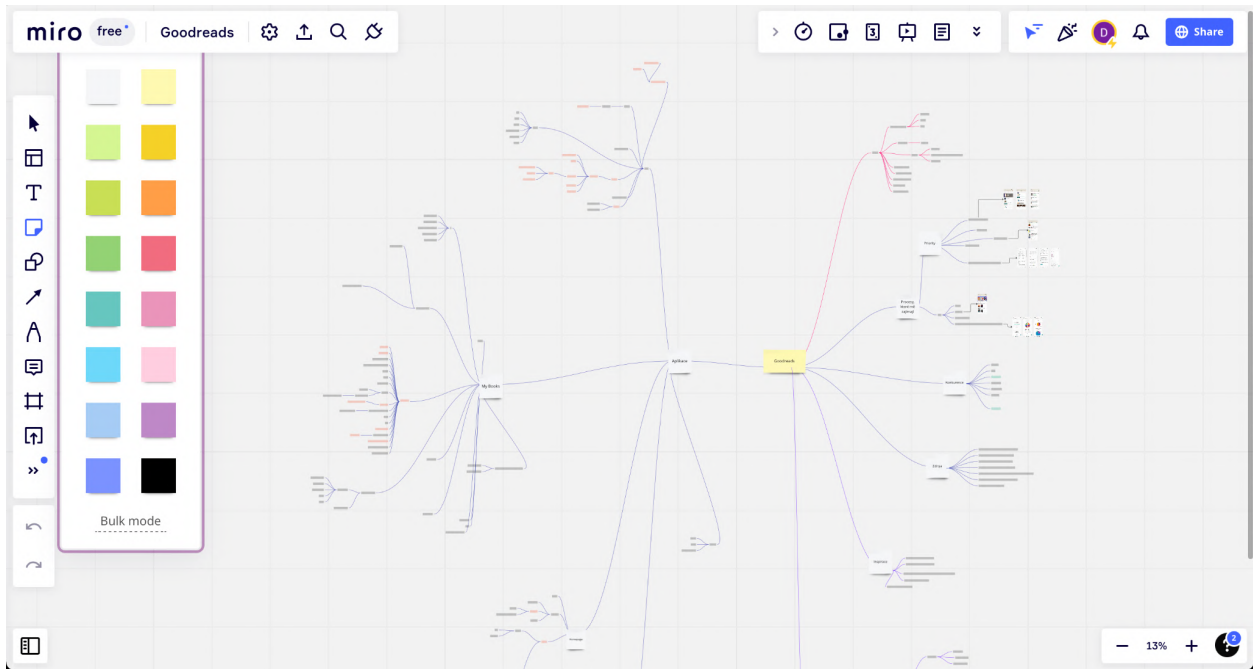


Figure 7 Miro, 2023



Figure 8 Paper prototype (© 2010-2023 UXPin Sp. z o.o.)

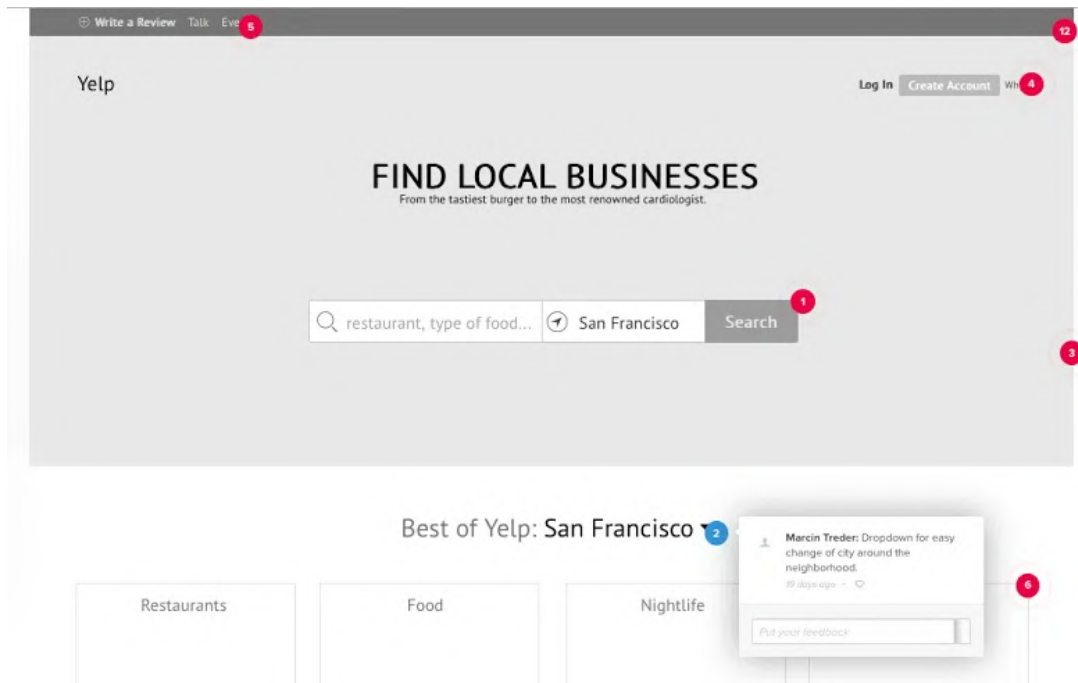


Figure 9 Low-fidelity prototype (© 2010-2023 UXPin Sp. z o.o.)

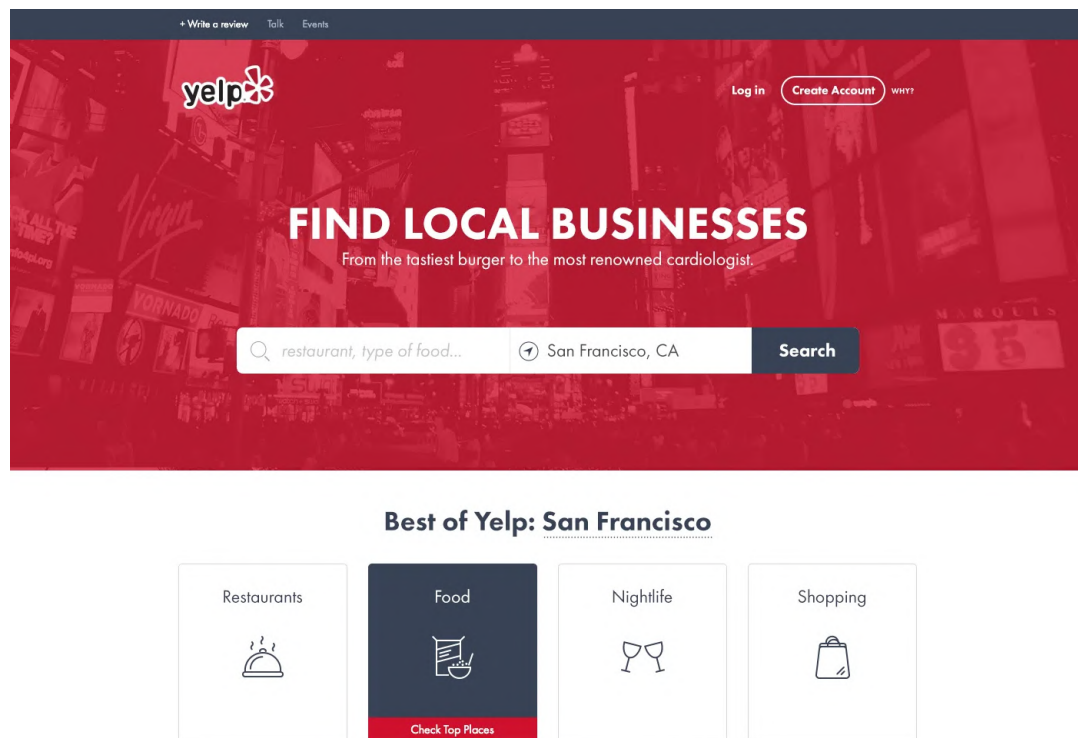


Figure 10 High-fidelity prototype (© 2010-2023 UXPin Sp. z o.o.)

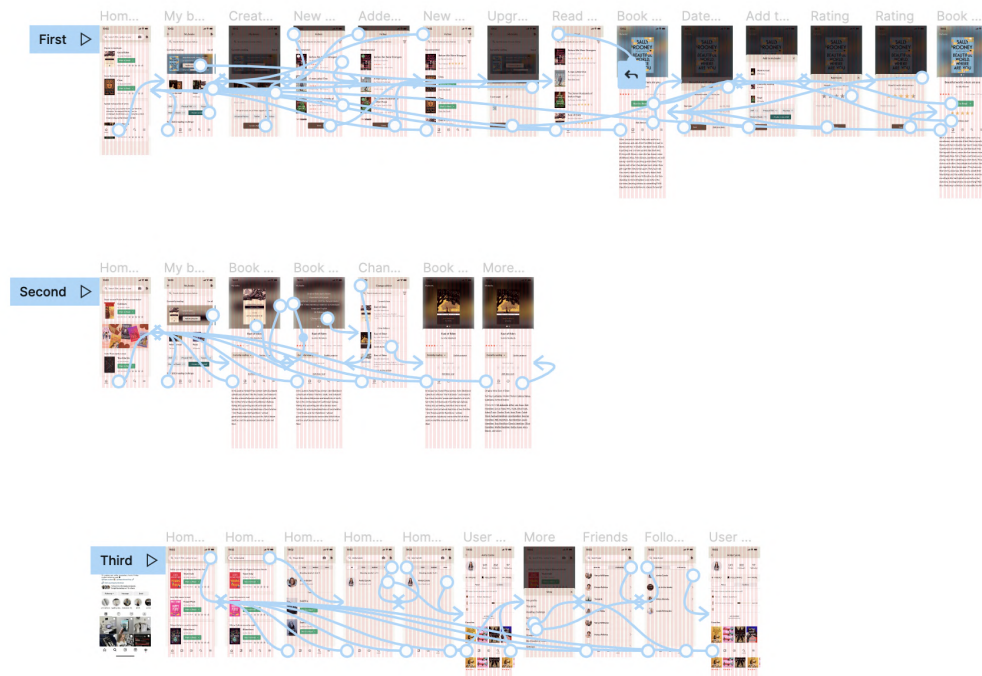


Figure 11 Interactive prototype in Figma, 2023

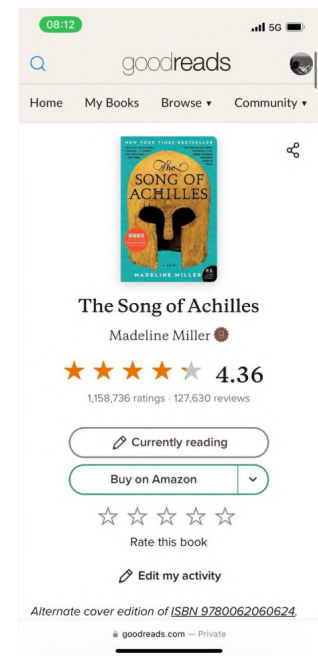
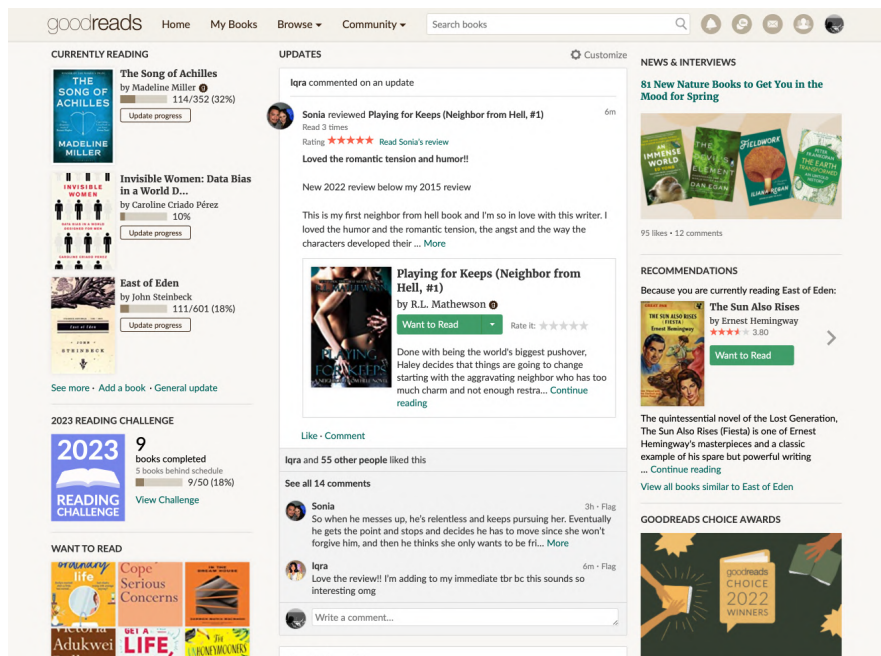


Figure 12 Goodreads.com, 2023

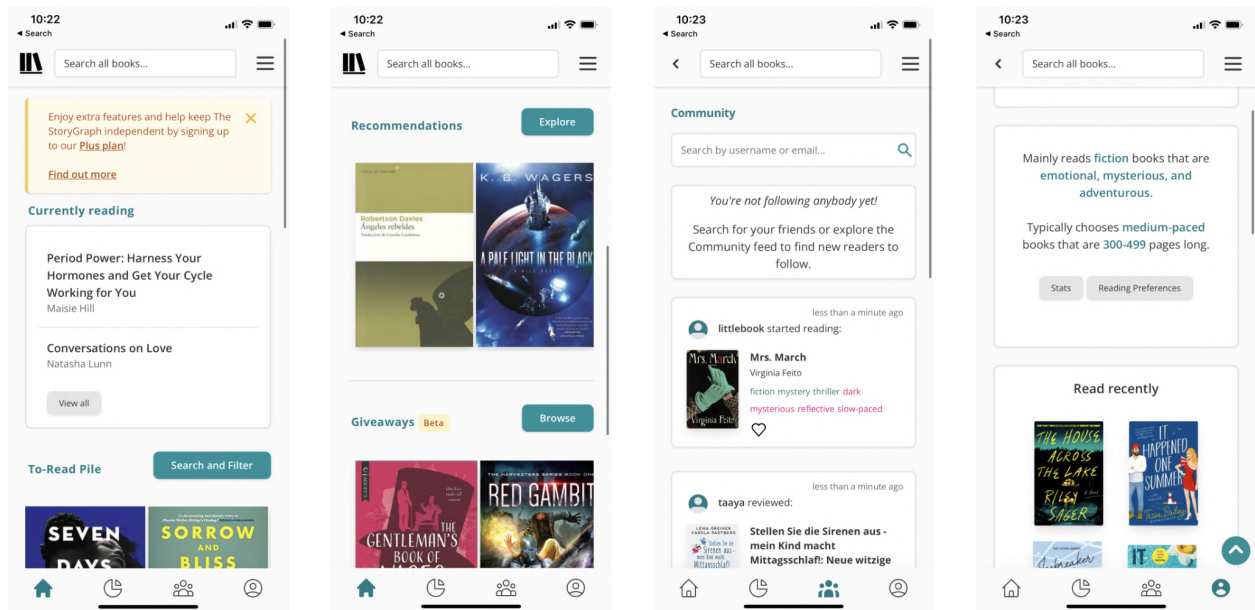


Figure 13 The StoryGraph, 2023

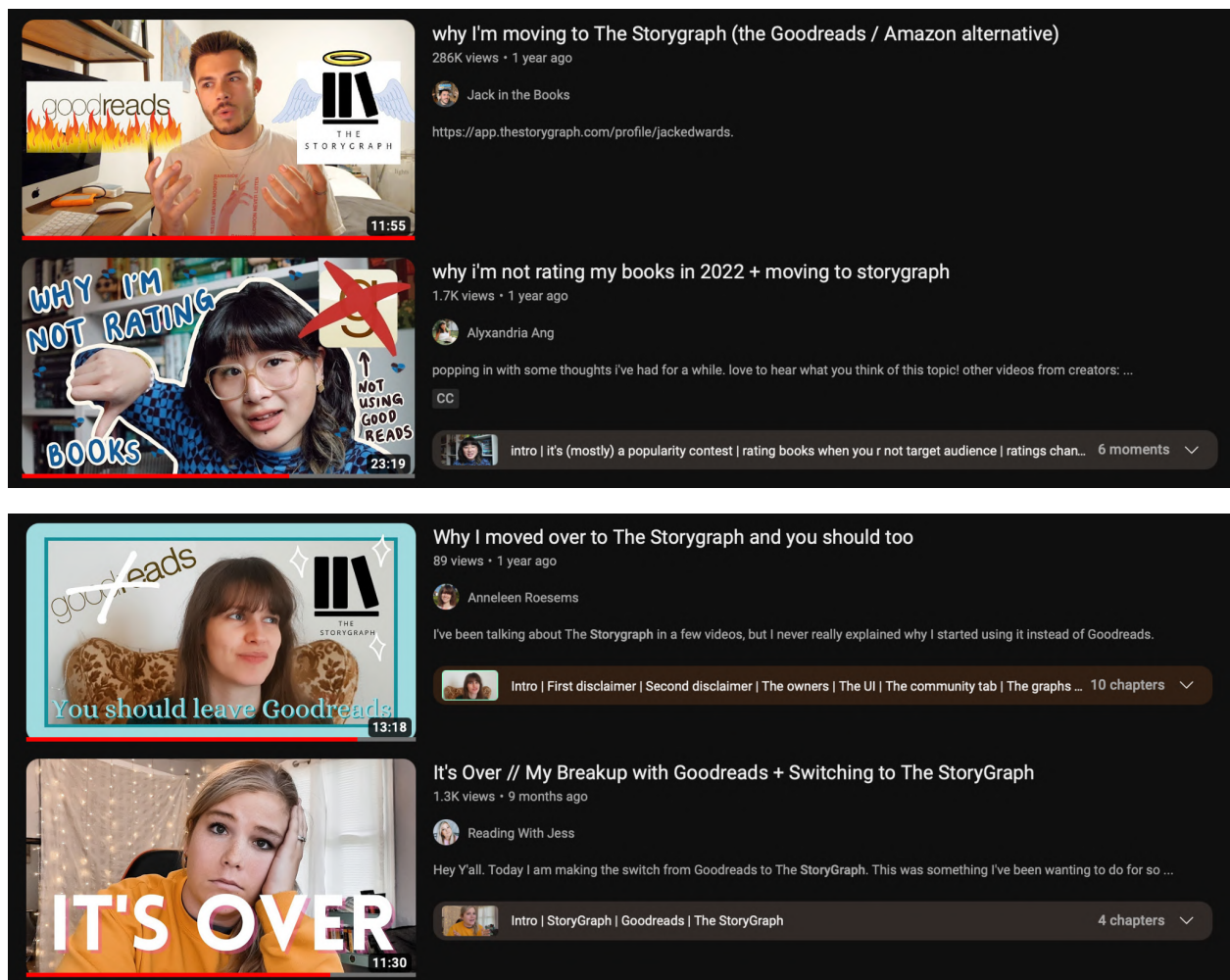


Figure 14 Screenshot from YouTube. Search result for “Why I’m leaving Goodreads”, 2022

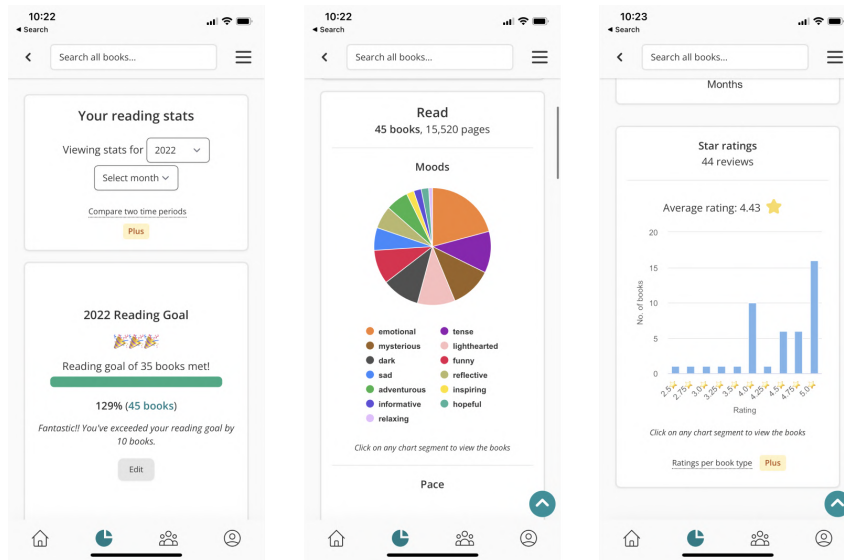


Figure 15 Personal reading stats on The StoryGraph, 2023

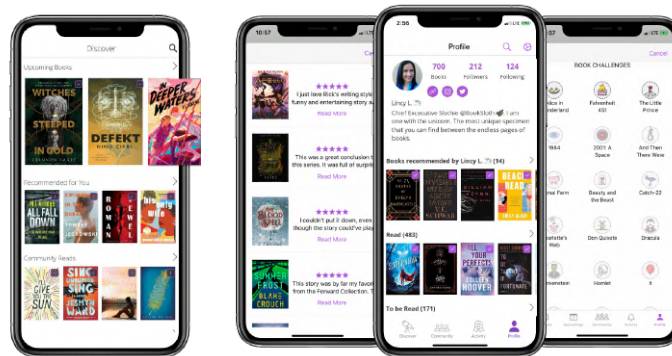


Figure 16 BookSloth (© 2018 BookSloth, Inc)

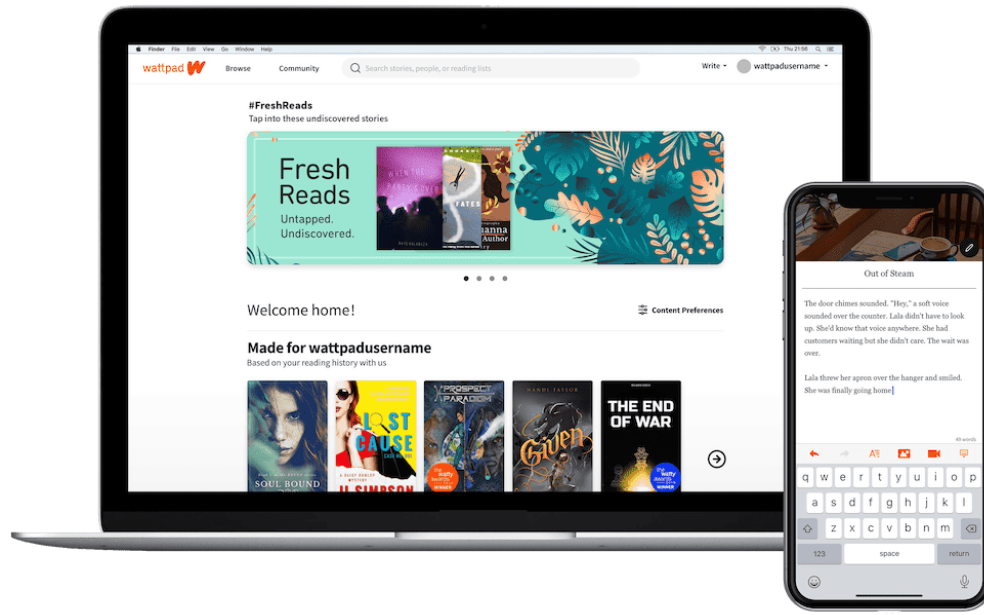


Figure 17 Wattpad (© 2023 Wattpad)

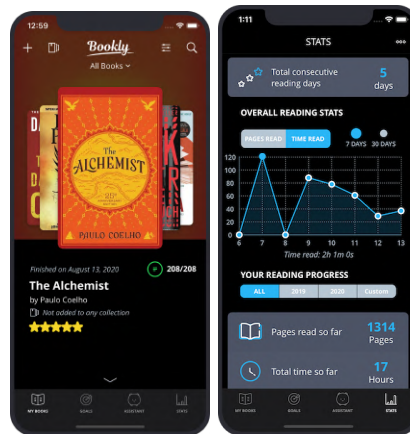


Figure 18 Bookly (© Bookly® 2023)

**Track films you've watched.
Save those you want to see.
Tell your friends what's good.**

GET STARTED — IT'S FREE!

The social network for film lovers. Also available on  



LETTERBOXD LETS YOU...



Keep track of every film you've ever watched (or just start from the day you join)



Show some love for your favorite films, lists and reviews with a "like"



Write and share reviews, and follow friends and other members to read theirs



Rate each film on a five-star



Keep a diary of your film



Compile and share lists of

Figure 19 Letterboxd (© Letterboxd Limited 2023)



peytonlam, 01/22/2023

Great if you're willing to give up some time!

The 2 stars I'm giving you is to get your attention. Your app is wonderful, and honestly, is one of only 2 on my iPhone that has (till now) been basically trouble-free. I use it all the time, and find it easy to use/intuitive, timely and filled with excellent information, (true story). Thanks for a great product.



donaldrumpslefttoe, 05/15/2021

Hi Goodreads. PLEASE ADD THESE THINGS

This app is wonderful. It is almost perfect. BUT every person I've talked to who uses Goodreads have all been in agreement it would be a GAME CHANGER if these were added:

- 1) A 0.5 star option. It sounds silly but it can be so frustrating deciding if a book is 4 or 5 stars. If there was a 4.5 option for example, I think all my life problems would be solved.
- 2) Private ratings. I'm sure if you're an app developer you know of Letterboxd, and for me personally, if some similar features could be added to Goodreads that would make it just "chefs kiss". For example: one of my favorite things about Letterboxd is how your ratings don't account to a larger average rating for a movie (but in this case it would be a book). You can rate a movie and write your OWN review describing how that movie fit into your personal taste. I would love to see this on Goodreads in a way in which I could do a private review (almost like a personal diary) rather than a public rating. Sometimes I'll read a book and recognize it's objectively a great book, but I might give it two stars because maybe that sub-genre of fantasy romance wasn't up my alley, so maybe that review would be nice to have in a personal journal rather than a public one because my review is sort of niche. I hope this makes sense. :))) I LOVE THIS APP!!!!

needs a revamp

I use this app religiously but it needs an revamp BAD. the UI looks like it hasn't changed since day 1 and it'd be nice if I could see my friends activity more often than I see ads on my feed 😊. would be nice if we could personalize our profiles, but not necessary. also recommendations or searching through genres could be greatly enhanced by further filtering of intended audiences—I don't want to scroll through twenty 20 childrens fantasy books before even finding one mediocre adult fantasy book I'm not interested in. ABSOLUTELY would benefit from half star rating system or even 10 star rating system I'm tired of seeing a 3 star review with "3.5 stars ..." or a 1 star review with "0.5 stars..." in the actual review. the app is also not super user friendly and is generally clunky. lots of unnecessary tapping needed and idk what it is but the searching function is super clunky too. I feel like the search option should first search our shelves for matches before searching the rest of the database for matches. definitely need a multi-select option to make shelving multiple books easier. I have over 300 books in my read I'm not reshelving each individual book, jeffrey. add tags in reviews so we can filter by tags. basically more filtering options for everything. add private reviews only your friends can see so that they don't affect the overall review of the book (sometimes you can acknowledge a book is well-written and still hate it).



the ink wyrm, 12/17/2021

Good but could use some improvements

Overall, I think this is a decent app for tracking your reading progress (though by no means the only one in its category). The process of finding a book, adding it to your shelf, tracking its progress, and leaving a review is simple and easy. It's when you spend a little more time on it that I think it could use improvement. I've included my complaints/suggestions below in order from most to least important.

- 1.) the thing that I find most annoying about this app is that when I go to edit down my want-to-read shelf, it constantly refreshes the page even if I'm not actually removing a book from it. Like I'll click a book just to remind myself what it's about, and when I click to go back to the shelf, it will refresh the page and I'll have to scroll back down to where I was. It's both annoying and inefficient to constantly have to be scrolling down the shelf to find my place (especially because I have A LOT
- 2.) shelf won't load beyond a certain point if you have a lot of books
- 3.) if I've DNF'd a book, there's no option but to add it to my read shelf, even if I add it to my separate DNF shelf
- 4.) adding a book to want to read shelf as part of a giveaway

x



raema00, 11/29/2021

needs a revamp

I use this app religiously but it needs an revamp BAD. the UI looks like it hasn't changed since day 1 and it'd be nice if I could see my friends activity more often than I see ads on my feed 😊. would be nice if we could personalize our profiles, but not necessary. also recommendations or searching through genres could be greatly enhanced by further filtering of intended audiences—I don't want to scroll through twenty 20 childrens fantasy books before even finding one mediocre adult fantasy book I'm not interested in. ABSOLUTELY would benefit from half star rating system or even 10 star rating system I'm tired of seeing a 3 star review with "3.5 stars ..." or a 1 star review with "0.5 stars..." in the actual review. the app is also not super user friendly and is generally clunky. lots of unnecessary tapping needed and idk what it is but the searching function is super clunky too. I feel like the search option should first search our shelves for matches before searching the rest of the database for matches. definitely need a multi-select option to make shelving multiple books easier. I have over 300 books in my read I'm not reshelving each individual book, jeffrey. add tags in reviews so we can filter by tags. basically more filtering options for everything. add private reviews only your friends can see so that they don't affect the overall review of the book (sometimes you can acknowledge a book is well-written and still hate it).

★★★☆☆ February 19, 2023

If you don't have this app already, don't get it! I am only still here because I've been kn Goodreads for a decade. Pretty sure none of the infrastructure of Goodreads has been updated for a decade, either. I am have been trying to unfollow one annoying and overactive author for *years* on both the desktop and phone app, and he still shows up in my feed (I'm not the only one with this kind of issue). It's awkward and not intuitive. It's just a place to keep a list of books you've read, that's it

★★★☆☆ January 16, 2023

I love this app! However, it would be so much better if it had the functionality to mark books as being re-read. It's unfortunate that if I want to re-read a favorite classic, it doesn't leave it in the Read pile and erases the record of it having been read before. It's very frustrating. Also, there needs to be an option for audiobooks. Goodreads is owned by Amazon but I can't add most of my audible books to my list to differentiate paper copies from audiobooks? Again, very frustrating.

★★★☆☆ January 9, 2023

Great for reading reviews, recommendations, keeping track of everything. The whole idea behind the app is great and honestly keeps me motivated to read. However, it's got some pretty big software and UI issues. Adding friends for example is embarrassingly hard. Looking up profiles, seeing what my own profile name is so I can tell people how to friend me is so confusing.

★★★☆☆ January 8, 2023

I pretty much use the app to make a book I'm currently reading and look up a review when I'm in the library or a book store. The rest (writing reviews, etc) I just do on the website. That's because the app is buggy and clunky. I've found books marked as Read instead of Currently reading. And recently Reviews don't show up at all under the books I look up. The most convenient thing is the scanner to look up a book to add to my list. That's it. The last update caused the bugs.

★★★★☆ December 8, 2022

The app is mostly a wrapper for a website. It does its job okay. I can keep track of books and look at reviews. But it doesn't have a dark mode, has very few settings, a lot of the pages are pretty basic, and the fact that a lot of the app is just a website has its own annoying problems.

Figure 20 App store & Google Play reviews, 2023

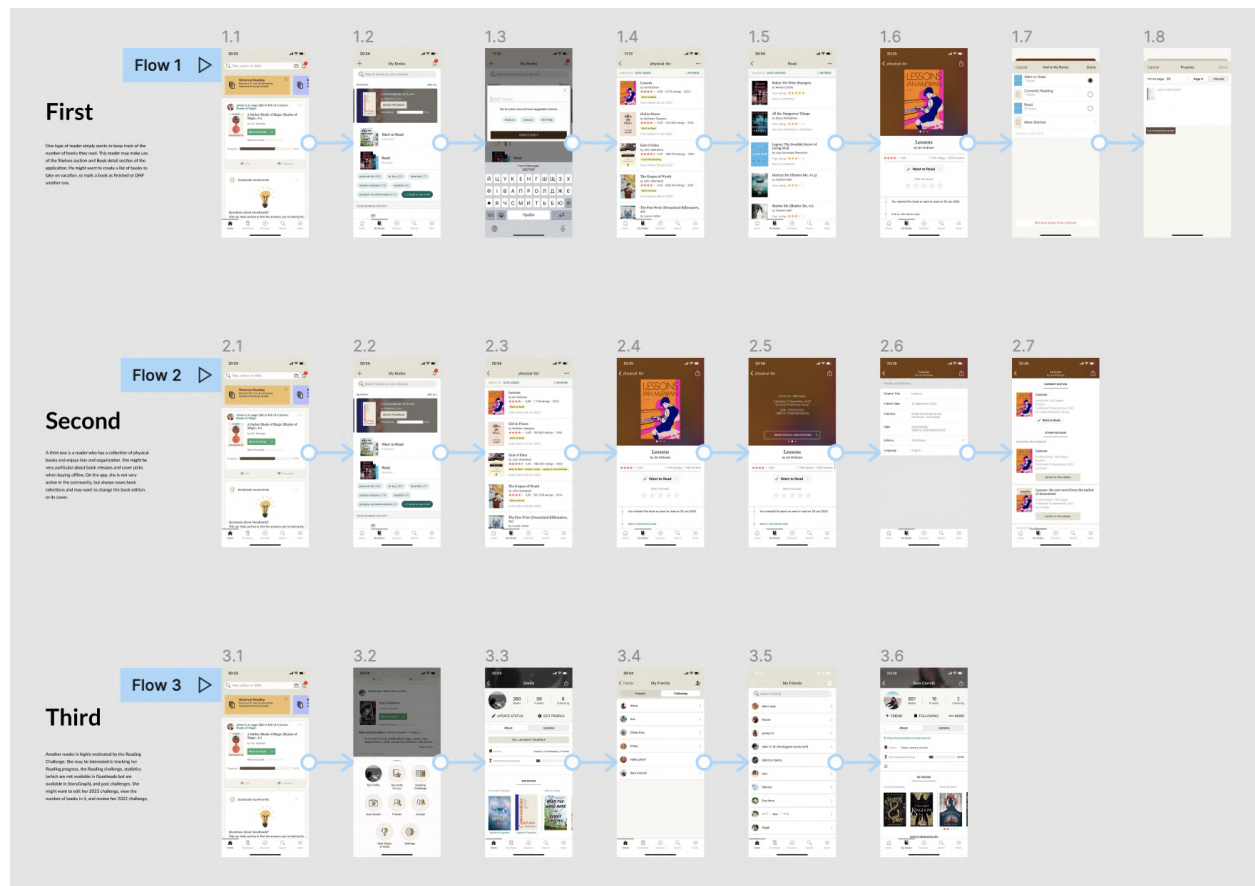


Figure 21 User flows in Figma, 2023

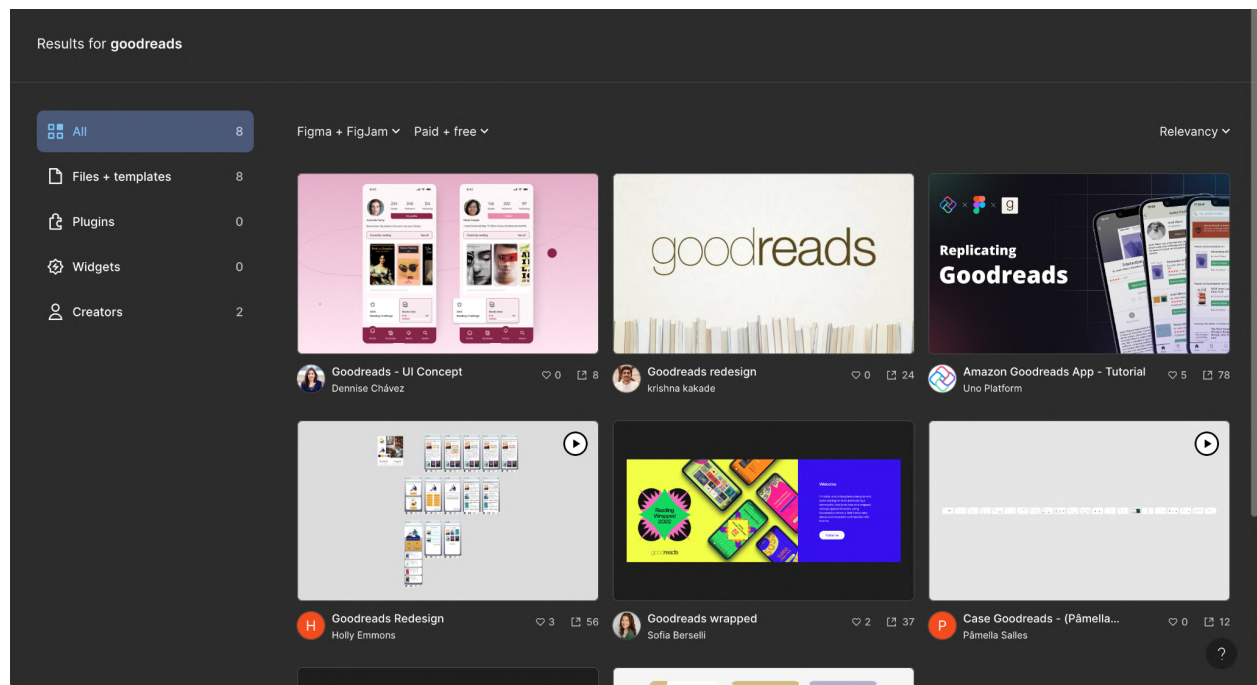


Figure 22 Search results for the word "Goodreads" in the Figma community, 2023

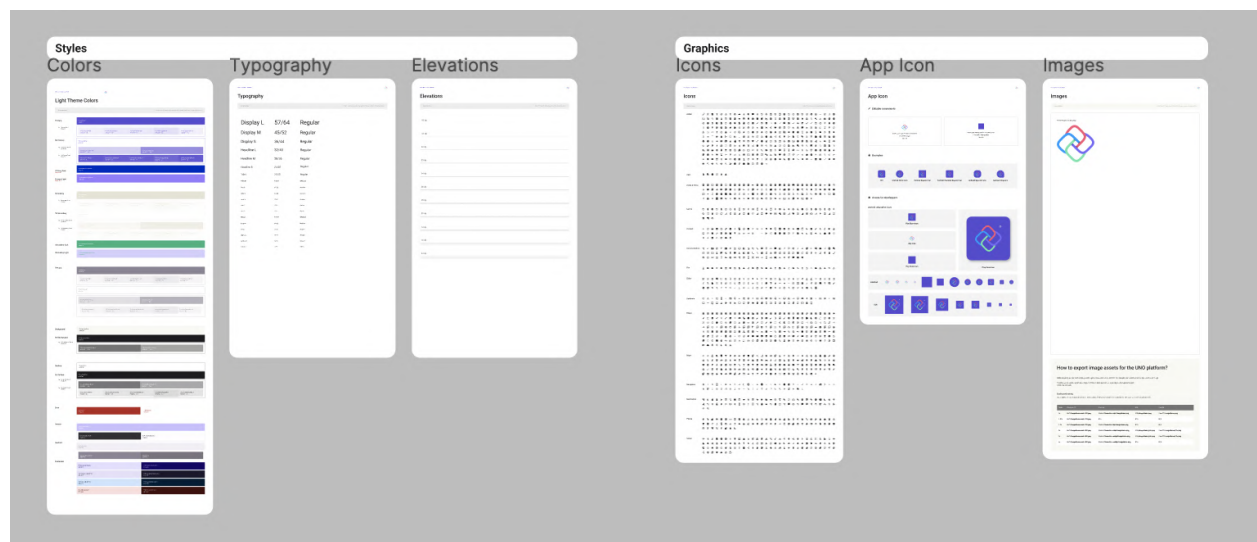


Figure 23 “[Replicating Amazon Goodreads App](#)” Design System by [Uno Platform](#), 2023

Display L	57/64	Regular	Heading 1	28/36	Regular
Display M	45/52	Regular	Heading 2	24/32	Regular
Display S	36/44	Regular	Heading 3	22/28	Regular
Headline L	32/40	Regular	Heading 4	16/24	Medium
Headline M	28/36	Regular	Heading 5	14/20	Medium
Headline S	24/32	Regular	Label 1	14/20	Medium
Title L	22/28	Regular	Label M	12/16	Medium
Title M	18/24	Medium	Label S	11/16	Medium
Title S	16/20	Medium	Label XS	11/16	Regular
Label L	16/20	Medium	Body 1	16/24	Medium
Label M	12/16	Medium	Body M	14/20	Medium
Label S	11/16	Medium	Body S	12/16	Medium
Label XS	11/16	Regular	Caption 1	13/18	Medium
Body L	16/24	Medium	Caption 2	12/16	Medium
Body M	14/20	Medium	Caption 3	11/13	Medium
Body S	12/16	Medium			
Caption L	13/18	Medium			
Caption M	12/16	Medium			
Caption S	11/13	Medium			

Figure 24 Uno Platform Text styles vs. Project text styles, 2023

Text styles	
▼ Typography	
Ag H1 · 28/36	▼ Body
Ag H2 · 24/32	Ag P1 · 16/24
Ag H3 · 22/28	Ag P2 · 14/20
Ag H4 · 16/24	Ag P3 · 12/16
Ag H5 · 14/20	▼ Captions
▼ Labels	Ag C1 · 13/18
Ag L1 · 14/20	Ag C2 · 12/16
Ag L2 · 12/16	Ag C3 · 11/13
Ag L3 · 11/16	
Ag L4 · 11/16	

Figure 25 Text Styles, 2023

Colors

Primary/Beige	#E6E2D6	Primary/Light beige	#F8F7F3	Primary/Light grey	#F5F5F5
Secondary/Brown	#E6E2D6	Grey	#999999	Secondary grey	#EDED
Dark green	#006561	Green	#4A9F77	Light green	#E5F0F2
Orange	#FF543A	Yellow	#FFBF6D	Purple	#87BFFE
Red	#F10000				

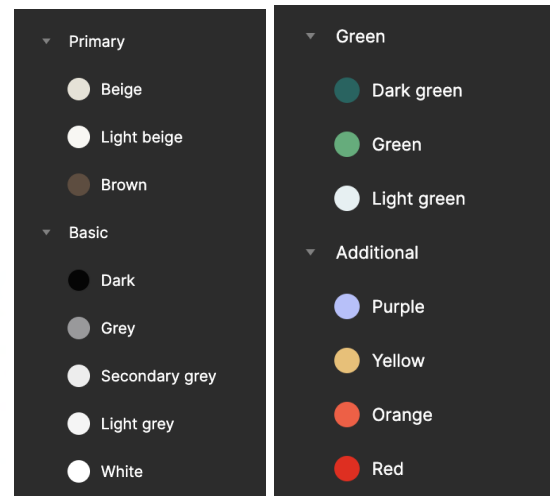


Figure 26 Color Styles

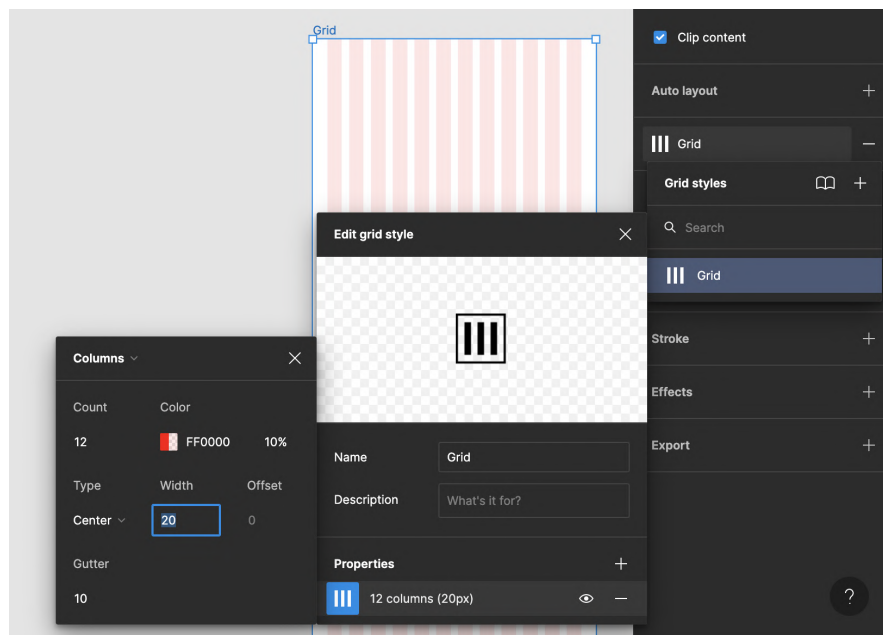


Figure 27 Grids, 2023

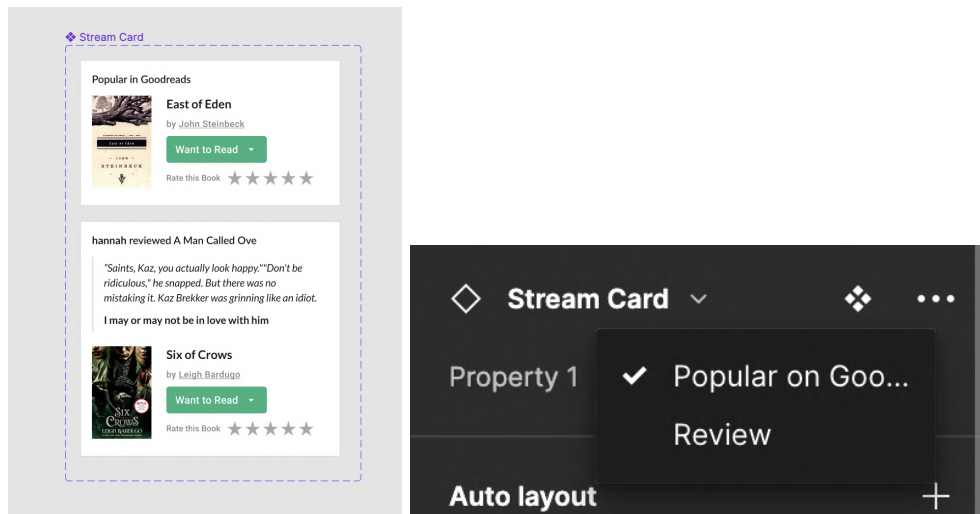


Figure 28 Components, 2023

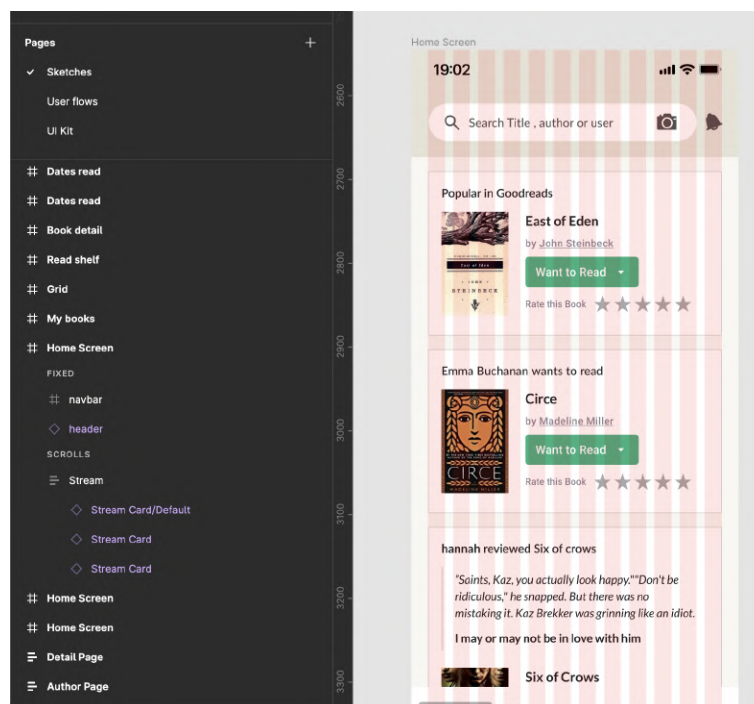


Figure 29 Auto-layouts, 2023

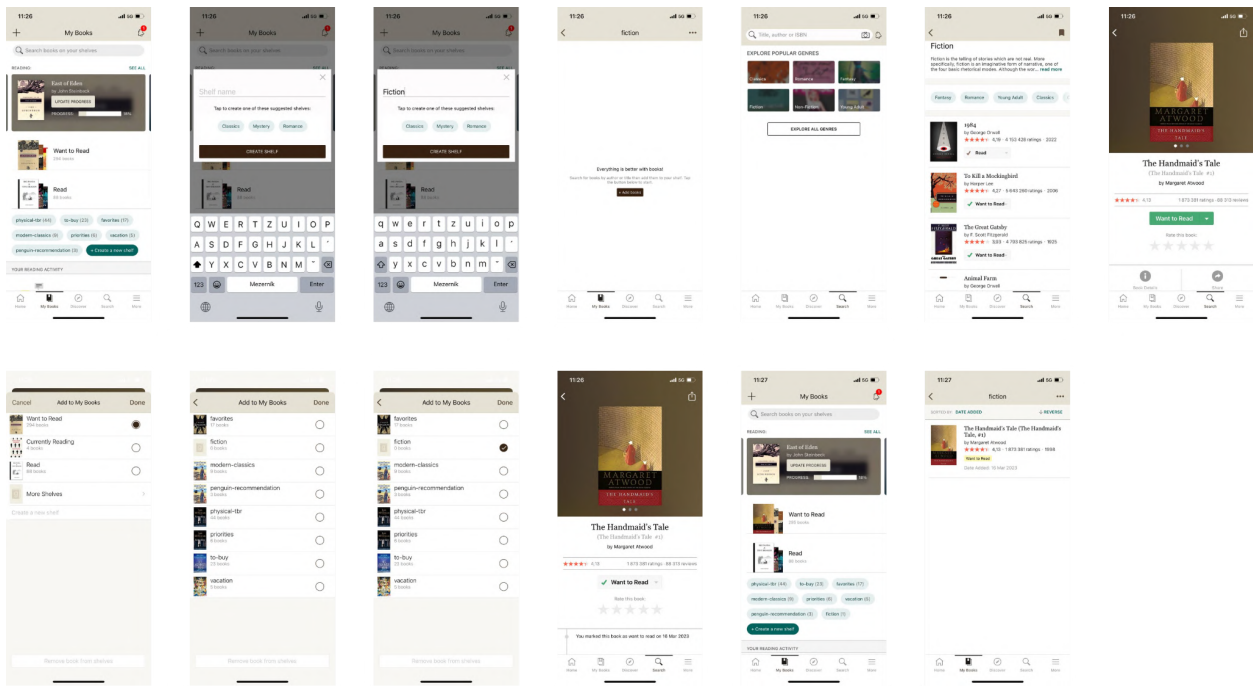


Figure 30 The user path of creating a new shelf in Goodreads, 2023

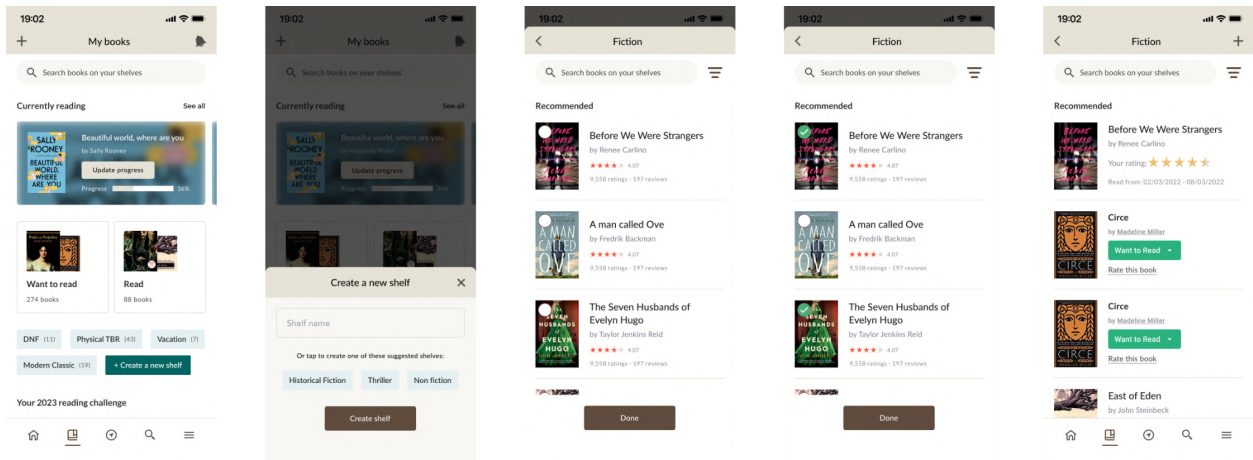


Figure 31 The new user path of creating a new shelf, 2023

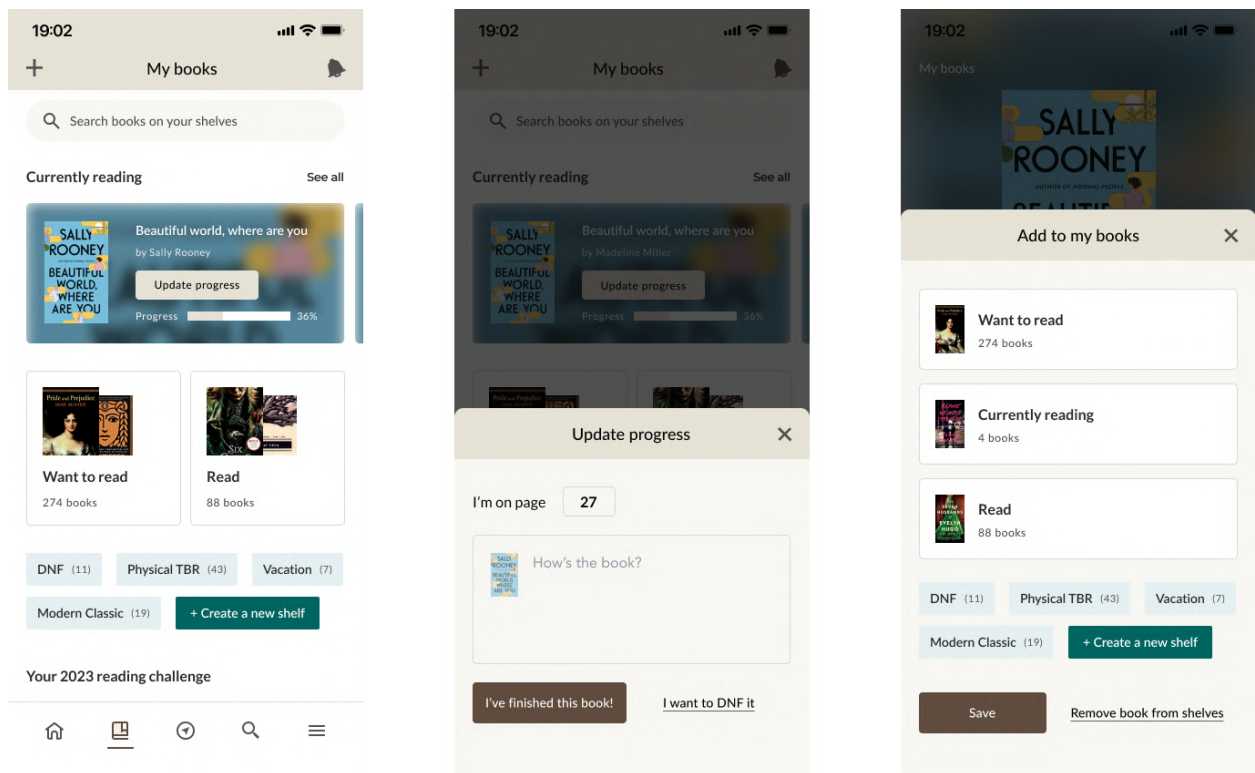


Figure 32 Marking a book as DNF, 2023

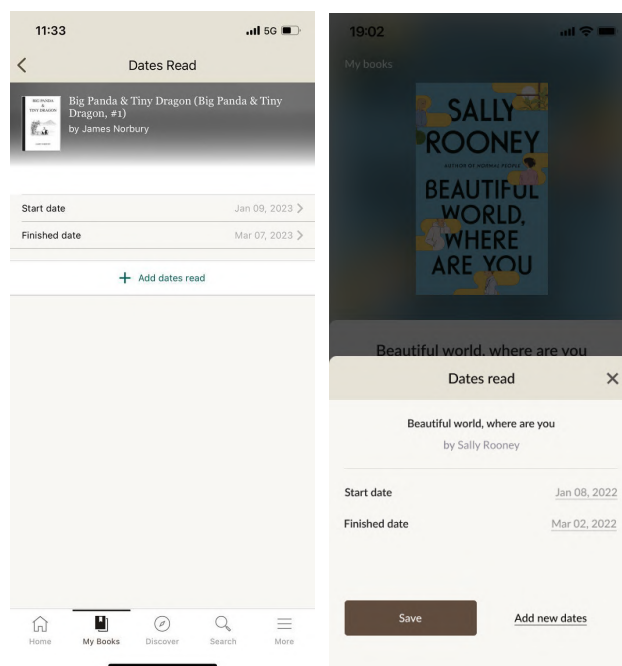


Figure 33 Dates read on Goodreads, 2023

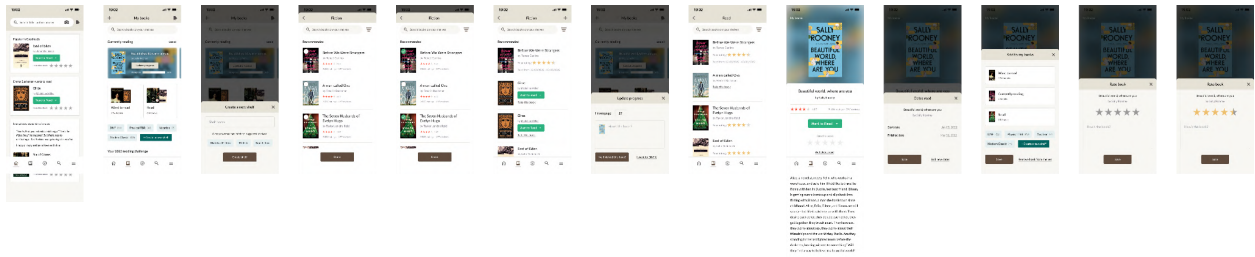


Figure 34 User flow of saving reading dates, 2023

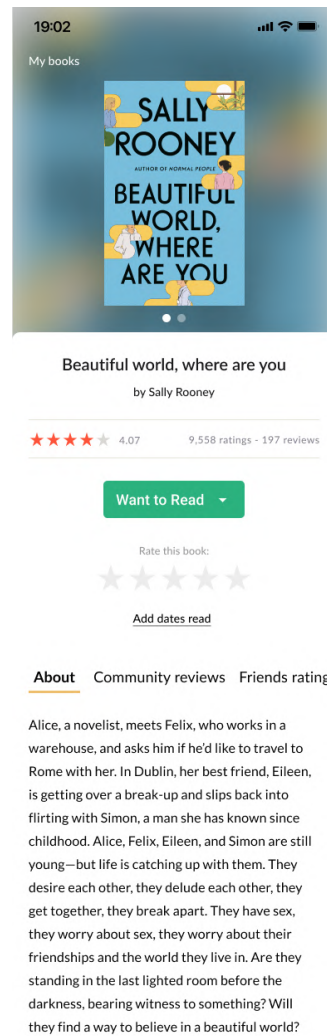


Figure 35 Book quotes, 2023

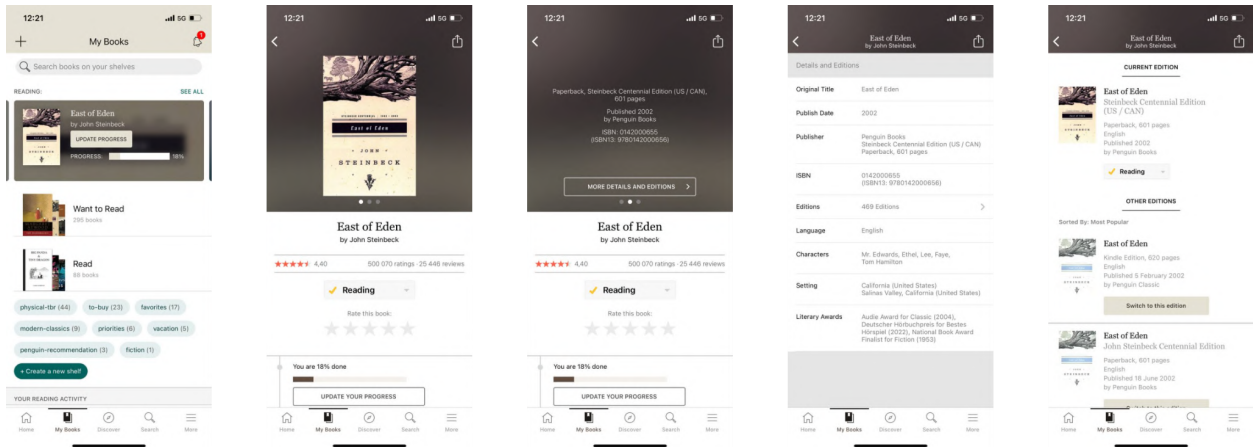


Figure 36 Second scenario, 2023

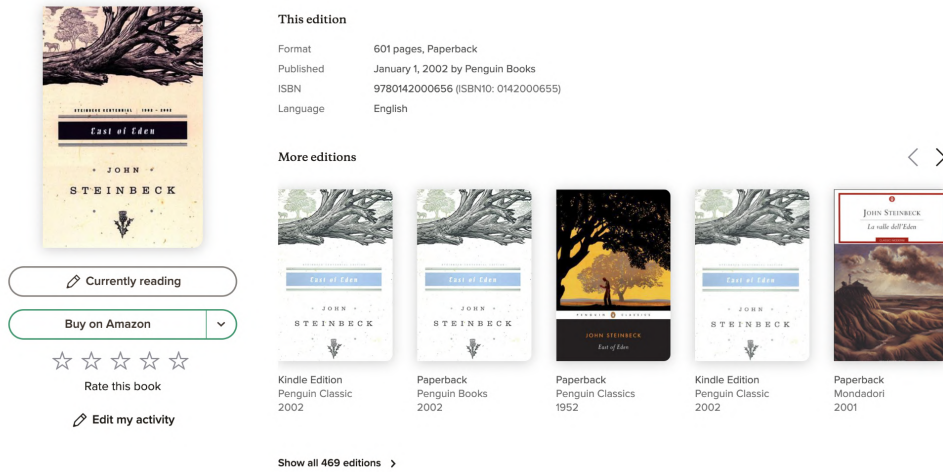


Figure 37 Changing book edition, 2023

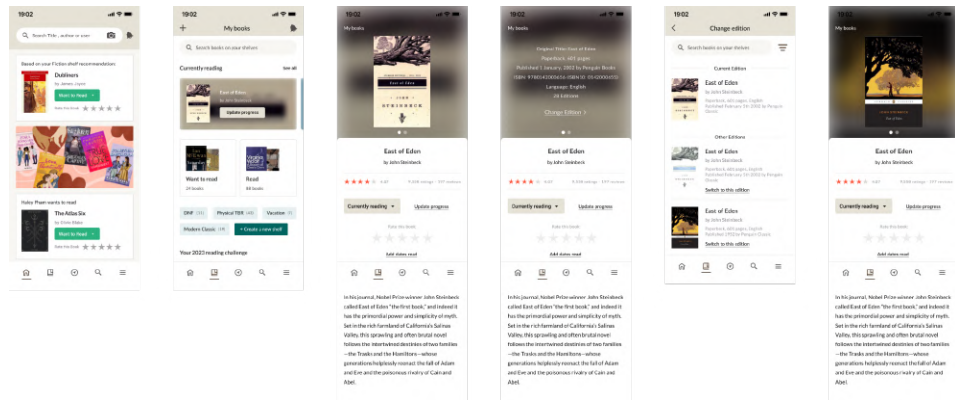
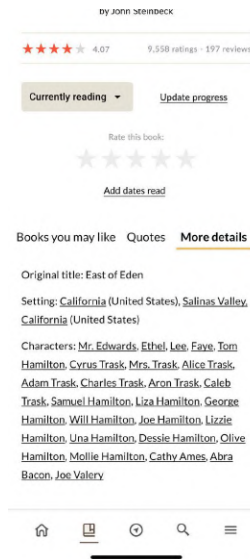


Figure 38 “More details tab”, 2023

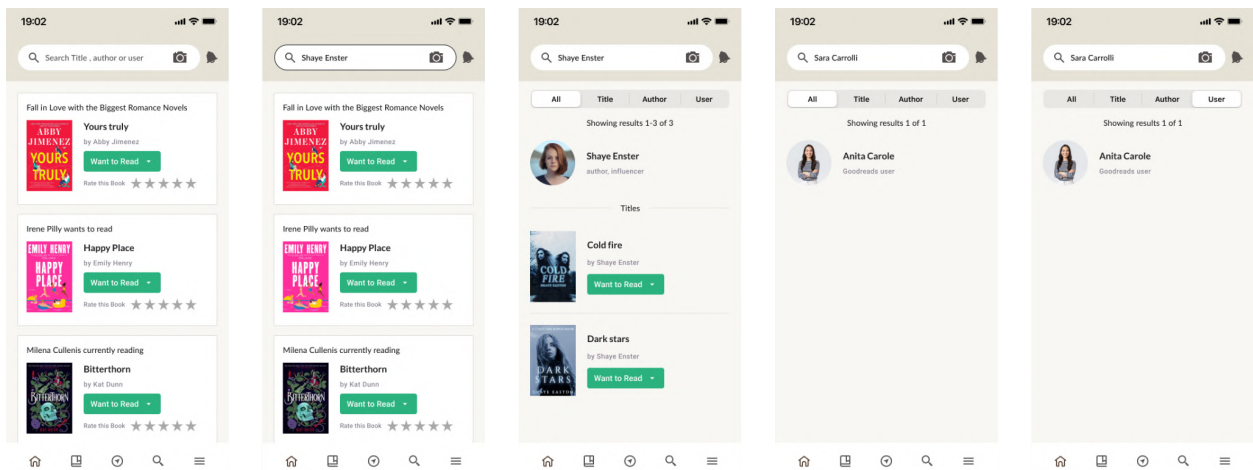


Figure 39 "Search Title, Author, or User", 2023

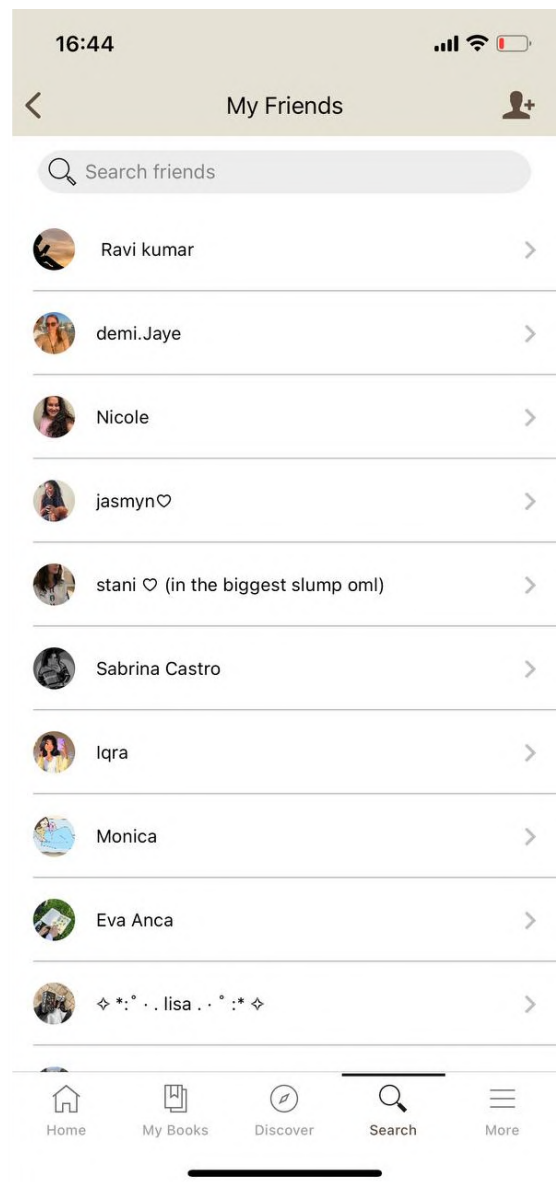
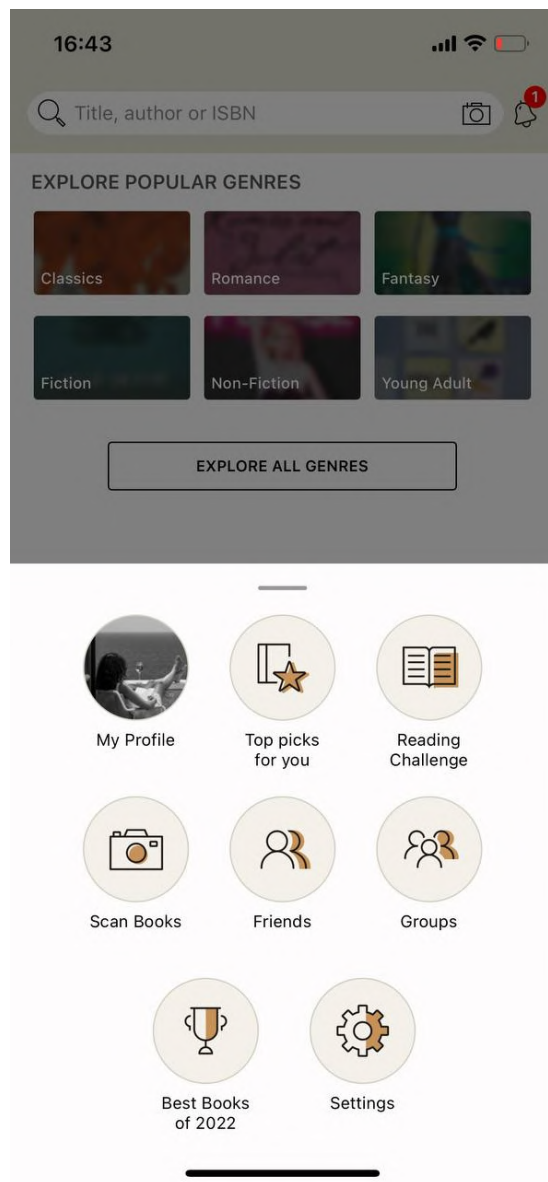


Figure 40 “More” section and “My Friends” page on Goodreads, 2023

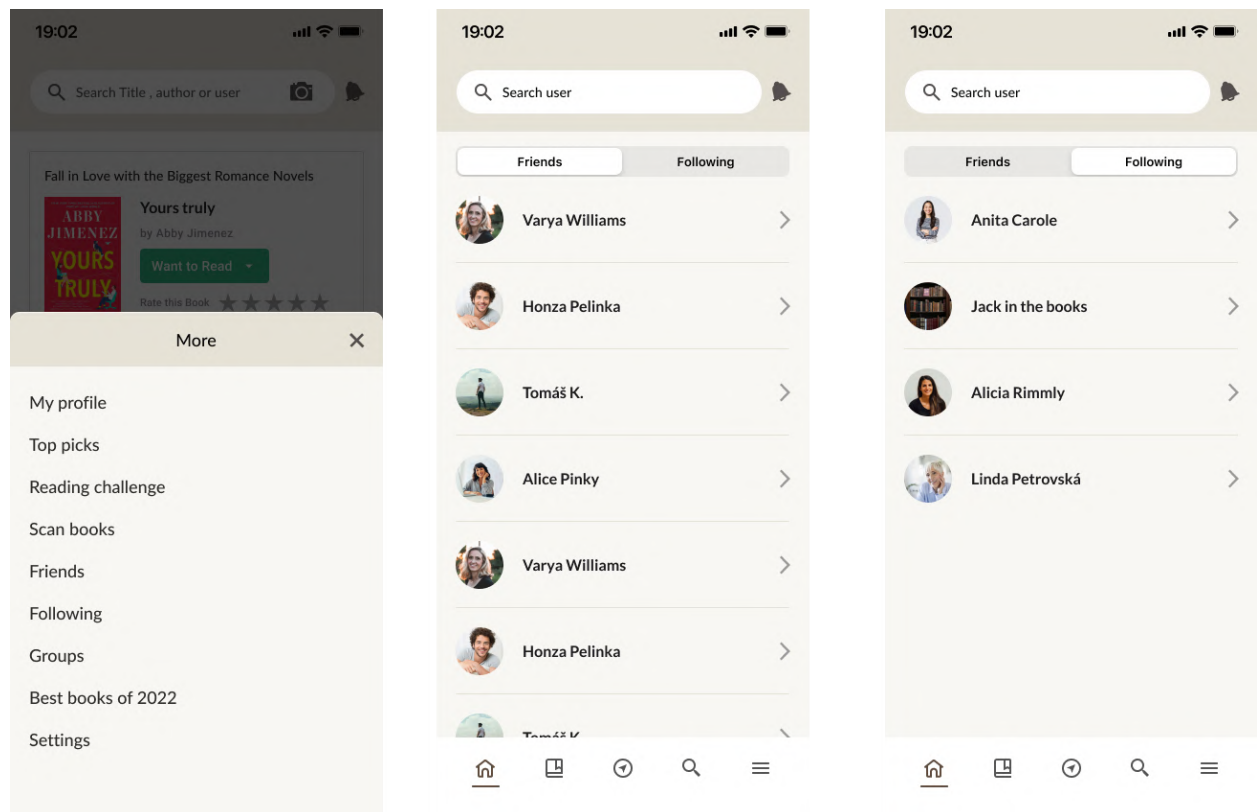


Figure 41 Adding a "Following" category on the "More" screen and a "Following" tab on the friends page, 2023

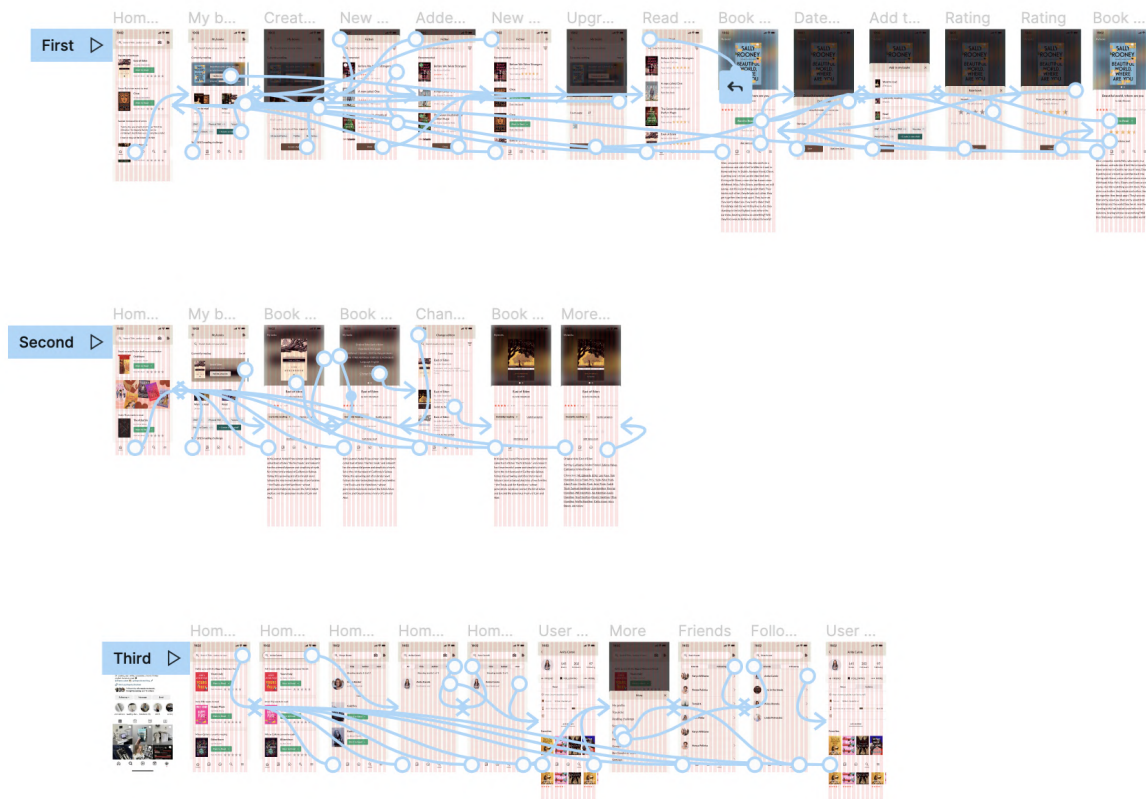


Figure 42 Interactive prototyping in Figma, 2023

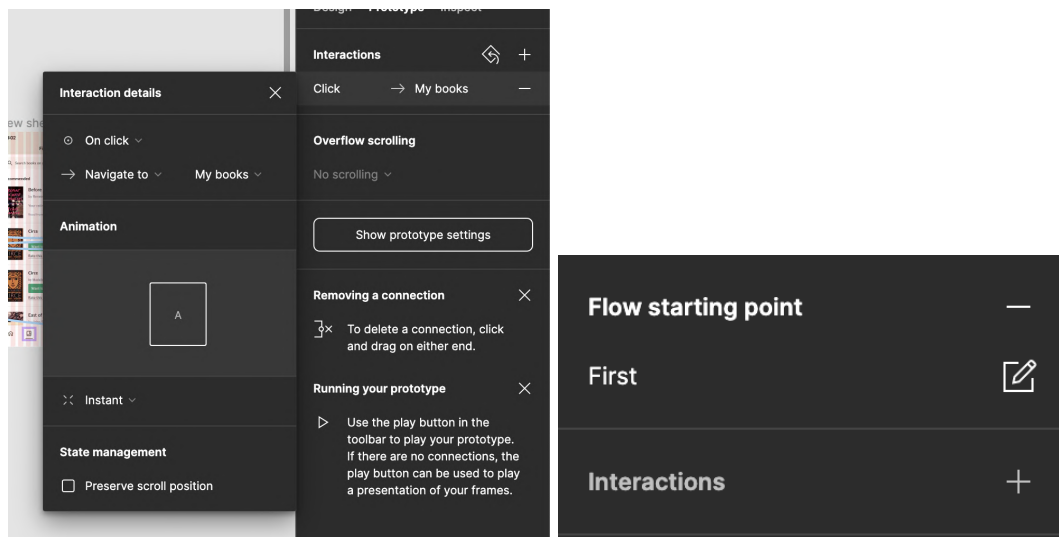


Figure 43 Interaction details, 2023

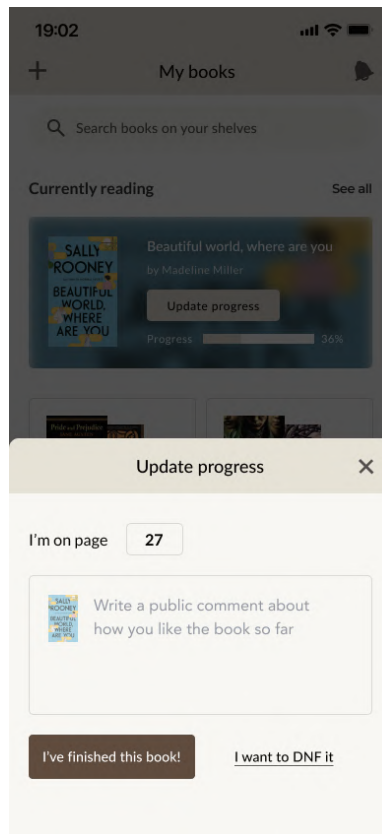


Figure 44 Update progress screen, 2023

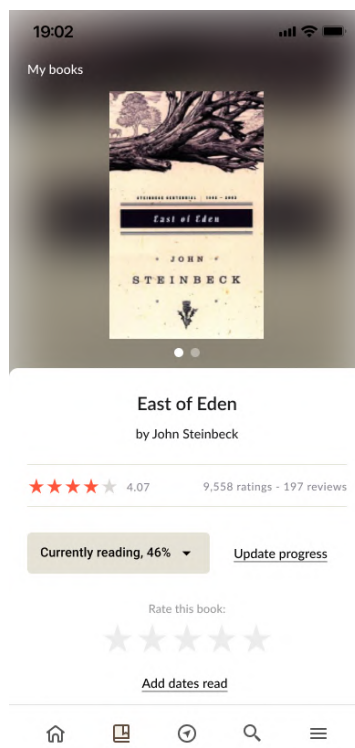


Figure 45 Book detail screen, 2023

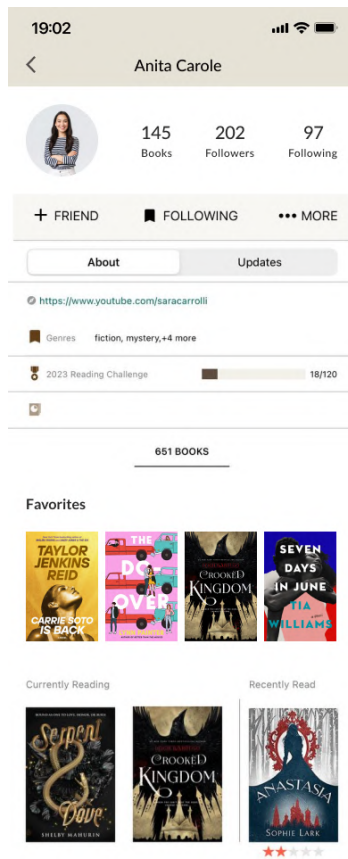


Figure 46 User detail screen, 2023